

Video Shelf

User Guide

Version 1.1 | For Windows 10 and Windows 11

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1. Welcome

Video Shelf keeps track of the video files you store across your hard drives. It builds a catalogue of every folder and scene, so you can browse, search, rate and play your whole collection from one place.

The catalogue lives on your PC, which means you can still browse everything when a drive isn't connected. You'll only need the drive when you want to play or change a file.

What you can do

- **Browse** folders and scenes as picture tiles, and preview a scene by moving the mouse across it.
- **Find** anything with search, filters and saved views.
- **Organise** with ratings, tags, your own categories and details, and covers chosen for you.
- **Explore** your collection through the Performers window and the Dashboard.
- **Tidy up** by finding duplicates, comparing look-alike folders, and clearing out what you no longer want.
- **Protect** your catalogue with safety copies on another drive, and an optional PIN.

What you need

Item	Requirement
Operating system	Windows 10 version 1809 or later, or Windows 11 (64-bit)
Disk space	About 500 MB for the app, plus room for your catalogue and screenshots
Video player	Scenes open in your Windows default video player

You also need **ffmpeg**, a free program that reads your videos and takes their screenshots. It isn't included with the app, and the next chapter shows how to get it.

> **About the pictures in this guide**
> The screenshots show a made-up collection of films and TV series, with drawn posters in place of real pictures.

2. Getting started

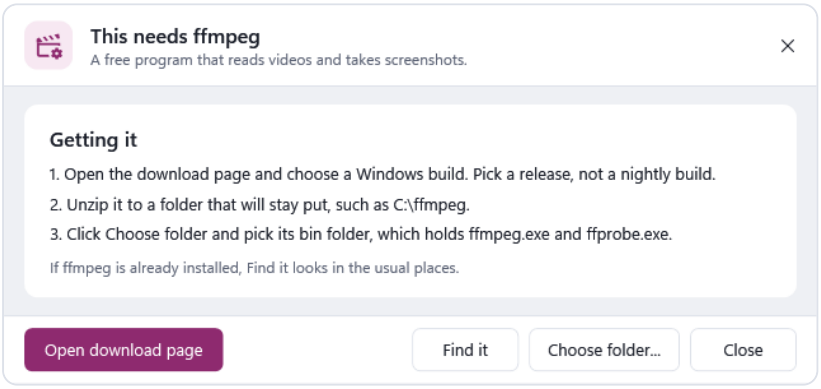
Installing

1. Double-click the setup file, `VideoShelf-Setup-1.1.0.exe`.
2. Choose **Install for all users** or **Install for me only**. Installing for everyone needs an administrator password.
3. Accept the suggested folder, or choose another, and click **Next**.
4. Tick **Create a desktop shortcut** if you'd like one, then click **Next** and **Install**.
5. Click **Finish**. Leave **Open Video Shelf** ticked to start it straight away.

> **If Windows shows a warning**
> Windows can show a SmartScreen message for newly released apps. If you trust where you got the installer, choose **More info**, then **Run anyway**. On a PC with Smart App Control switched on, Windows may not let the installer run at all.

Getting ffmpeg

Until ffmpeg is set up, an **ffmpeg needed** button shows in the status bar, and anything that reads a video asks for it first.

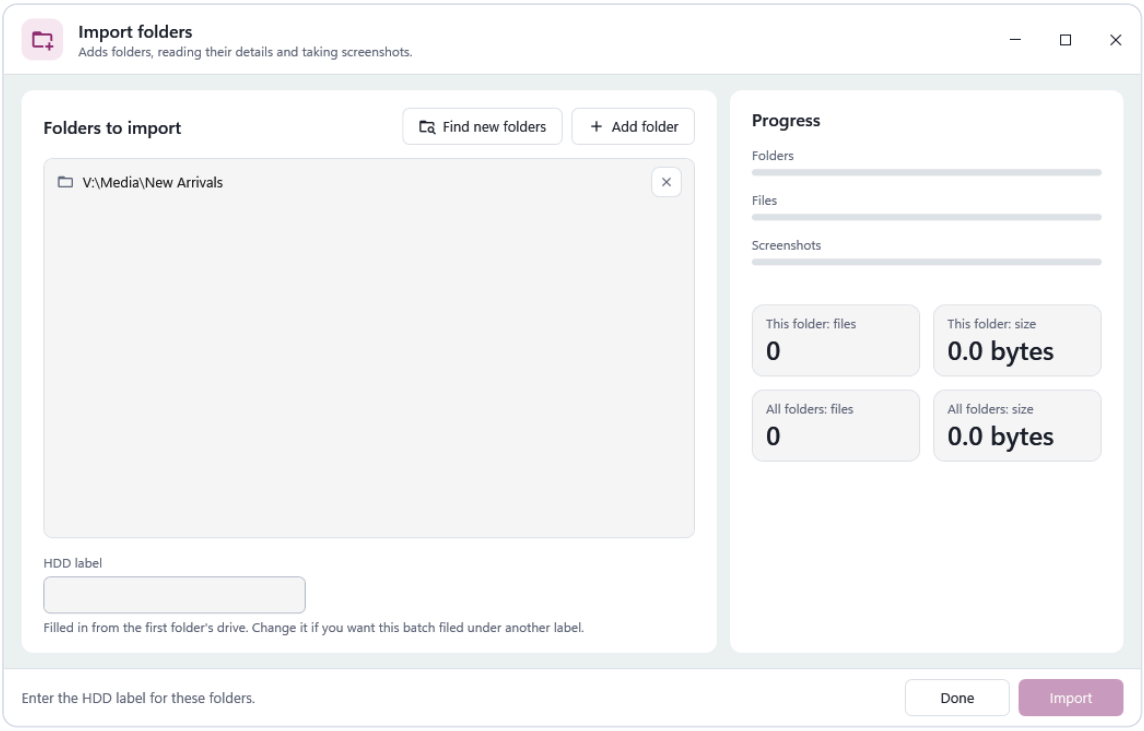


Setting up ffmpeg

1. Click **ffmpeg needed**, then **Open download page**, and choose a Windows release build.
2. Unzip it to a folder that will stay put, such as `C:\ffmpeg`.
3. Click **Choose folder...** and pick its `bin` folder, which holds `ffmpeg.exe` and `ffprobe.exe`. If ffmpeg is already installed, **Find it** looks in the usual places.

Adding your first folder

1. Choose **File > Import Folder(s)...**
2. Click **Add folder**, or drag folders into the window. To pick up several at once, click **Find new folders**, choose one connected drive and search it: Video Shelf looks beside the folders you already have on that drive, and you tick the ones to add. Every folder needs its own name across your collection, even on different drives, so a folder whose name is taken can't be added until you rename it on the drive.
3. Check the **HDD label**. It's filled in from the drive, and you can change it if this batch belongs under another label.
4. Click **Import**. Video Shelf reads each video and takes its screenshots.



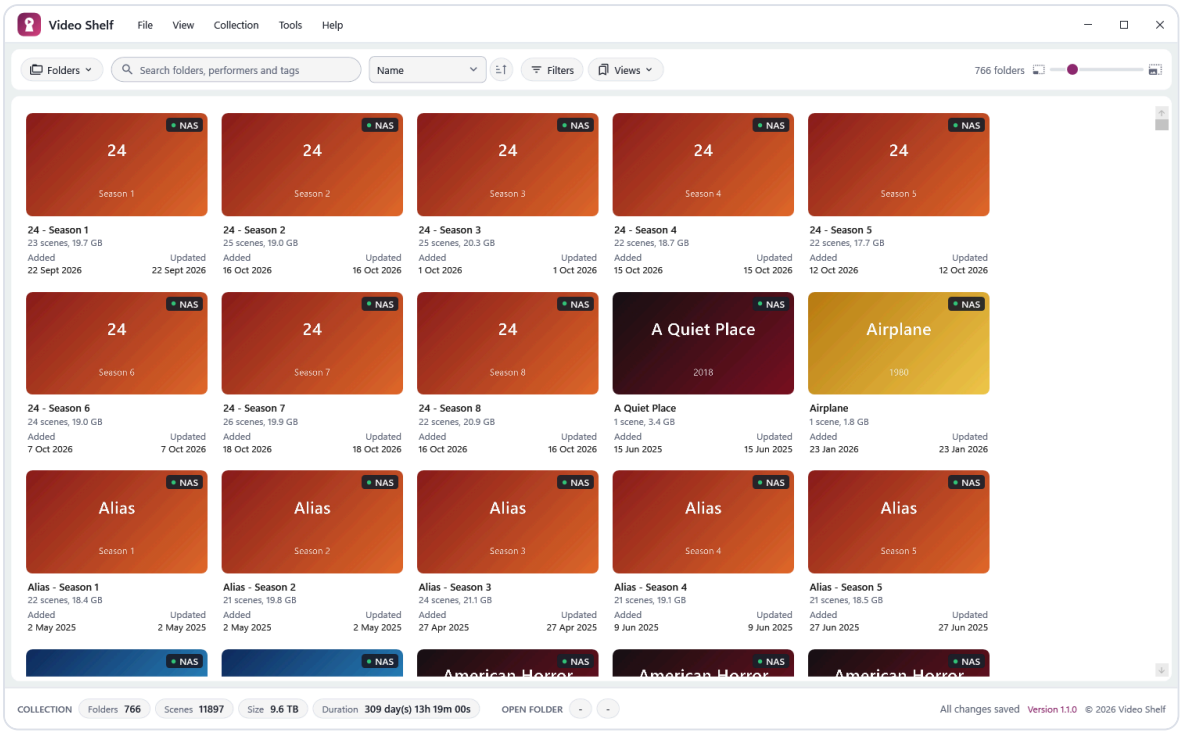
The Import Folders window, with a folder ready to import

> **Your videos aren't moved**
> Importing only adds them to the catalogue. Your files stay exactly where they are.

Uninstalling

Use **Settings > Apps** in Windows, or **Uninstall Video Shelf** in the Start menu. This removes the app only. Your catalogue, ratings and videos stay in place, so reinstalling picks up where you left off.

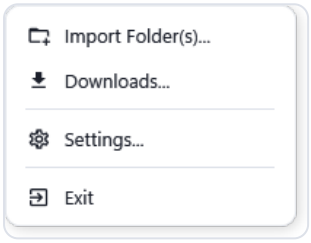
3. A tour of the main window



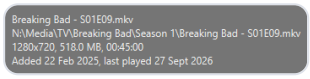
The main window showing folders

The menus

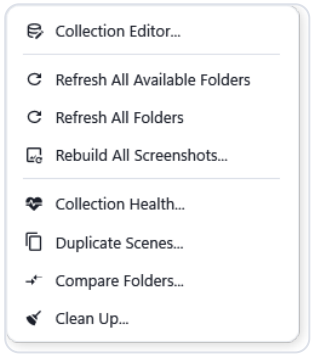
Menu	What's there
File	Import folders, Downloads, Settings and Exit
View	Top 100 Played, Last 100 Played, 5-Star Ratings, Performers, Dashboard and Hard Drive Info
Collection	Collection Editor, refreshing folders, Rebuild All Screenshots, Collection Health, Duplicate Scenes, Compare Folders and Clean Up
Tools	Torrent Check, Folder Duplicates, Optimise Screenshots, Favourites sync, copying to a drive and clean-up tools
Help	User Guide, What's New, Check for Updates, Activity Log, System Information and About



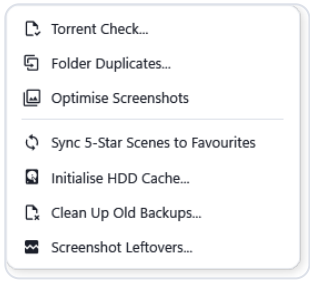
File



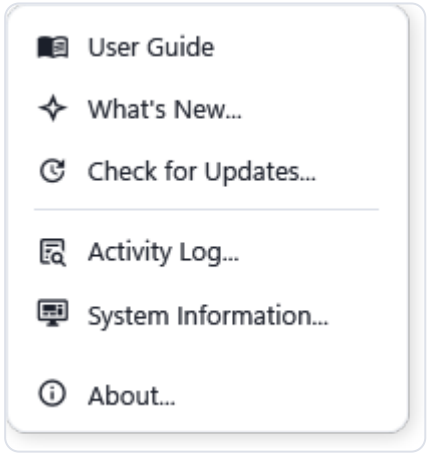
View



Collection



Tools

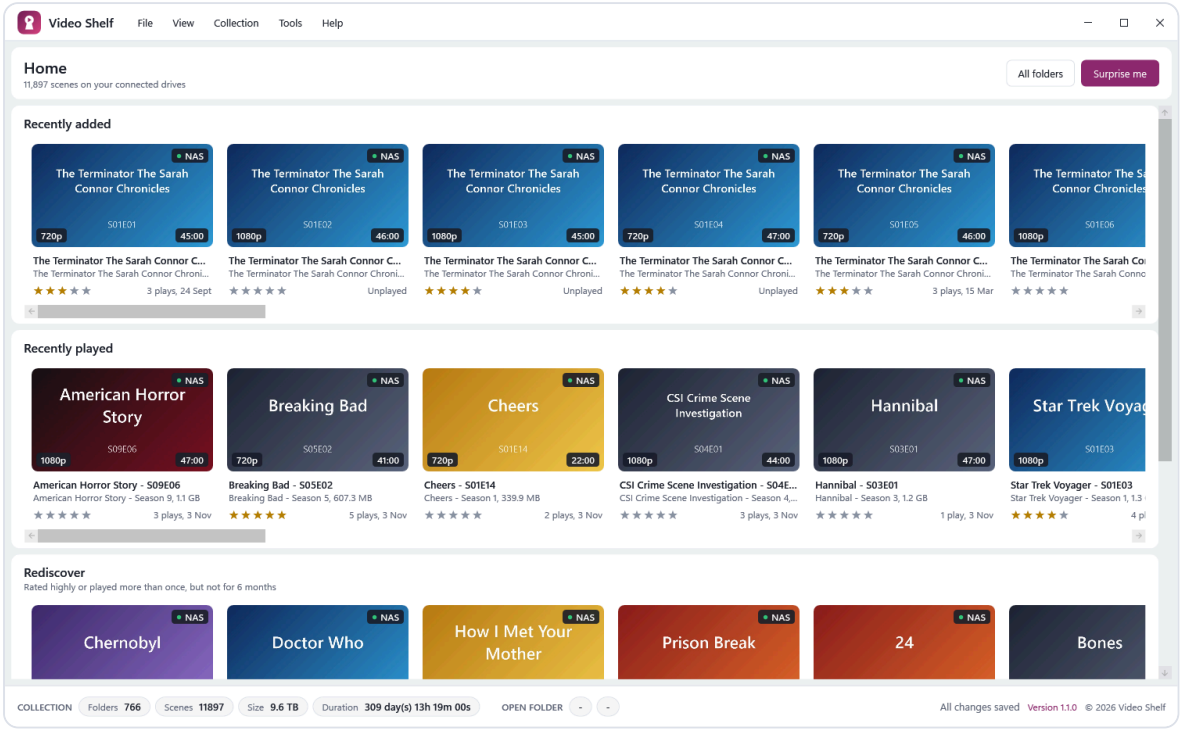


Help

Your own folder details
Use **Settings > Attributes** to add details of your own to folders and scenes, such as Studio, Publisher or Year of Release, as text, a number or a date. Fill them in from Edit Details, or for several scenes at once from the selection bar. Each one becomes a filter for folders and scenes. Scenes can go in categories of their own too. A scene counts as having its folder's categories and attributes, and a value set on the scene takes priority.

Home

Home brings together recently added scenes, what you've played lately, highly rated scenes you haven't watched for six months, and a random handful you've never played. **Surprise me** plays a random scene, choosing from your top-rated ones if you have any. **All folders** takes you back to the folder tiles. The first button on the filter bar switches between **Home**, **Folders** and **All scenes** too.

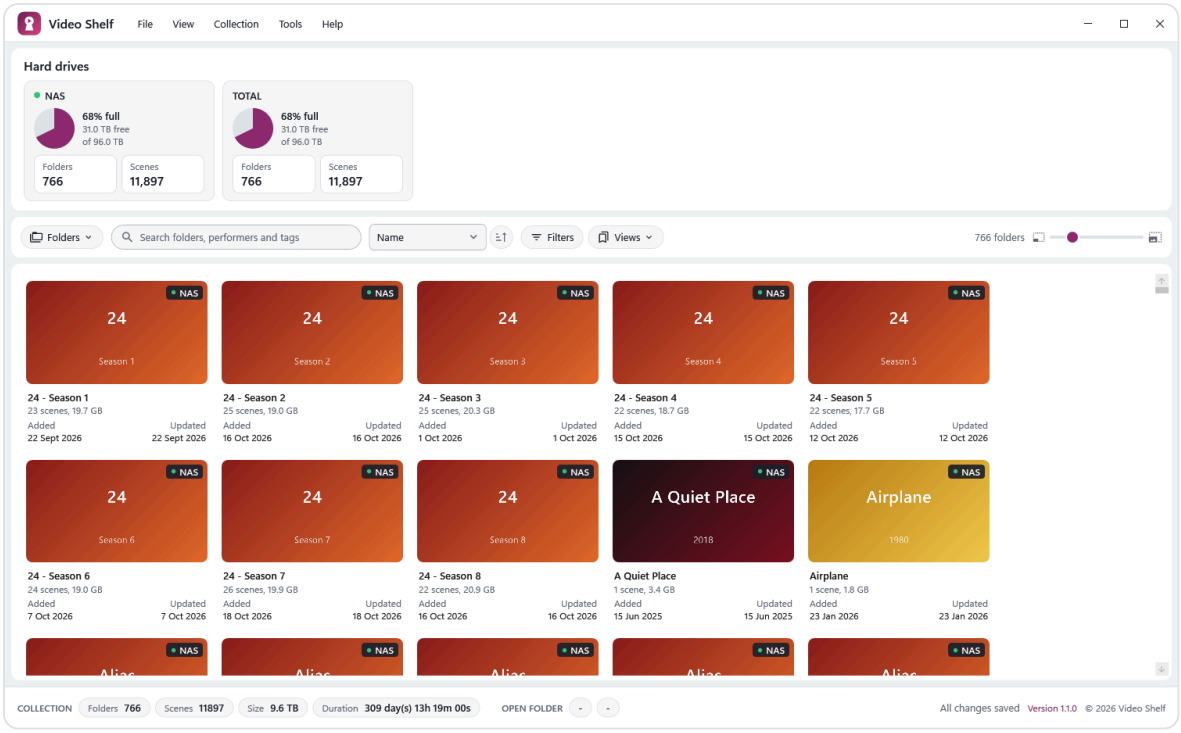


The Home view

> **Make Home your starting point**
>
> Go to **Settings > Display** and set **When the app opens** to **Show Home**.

Hard drives

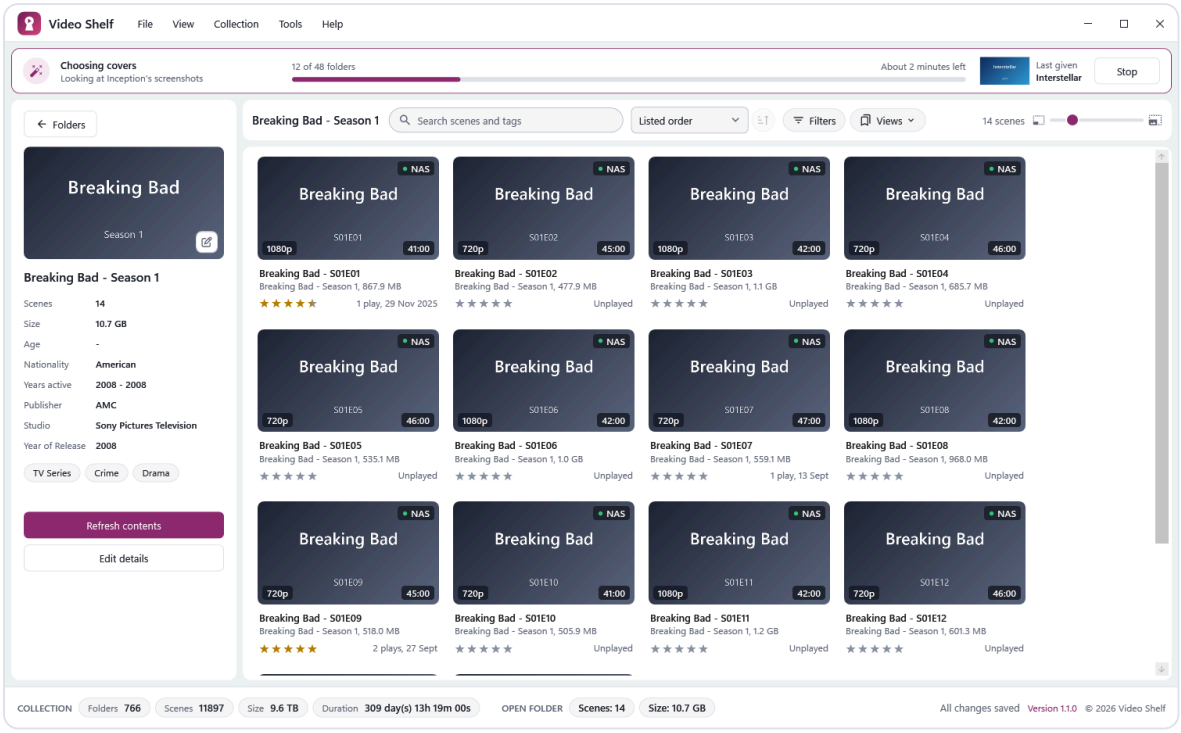
Choose **View > Hard Drive Info** to see a panel listing each drive, how full it is, and how many folders and scenes it holds. Drives remembered in your catalogue are listed even while they're disconnected. Each folder tile shows its drive's label, with a green dot while the drive is connected.



The Hard Drive Info panel above the folders

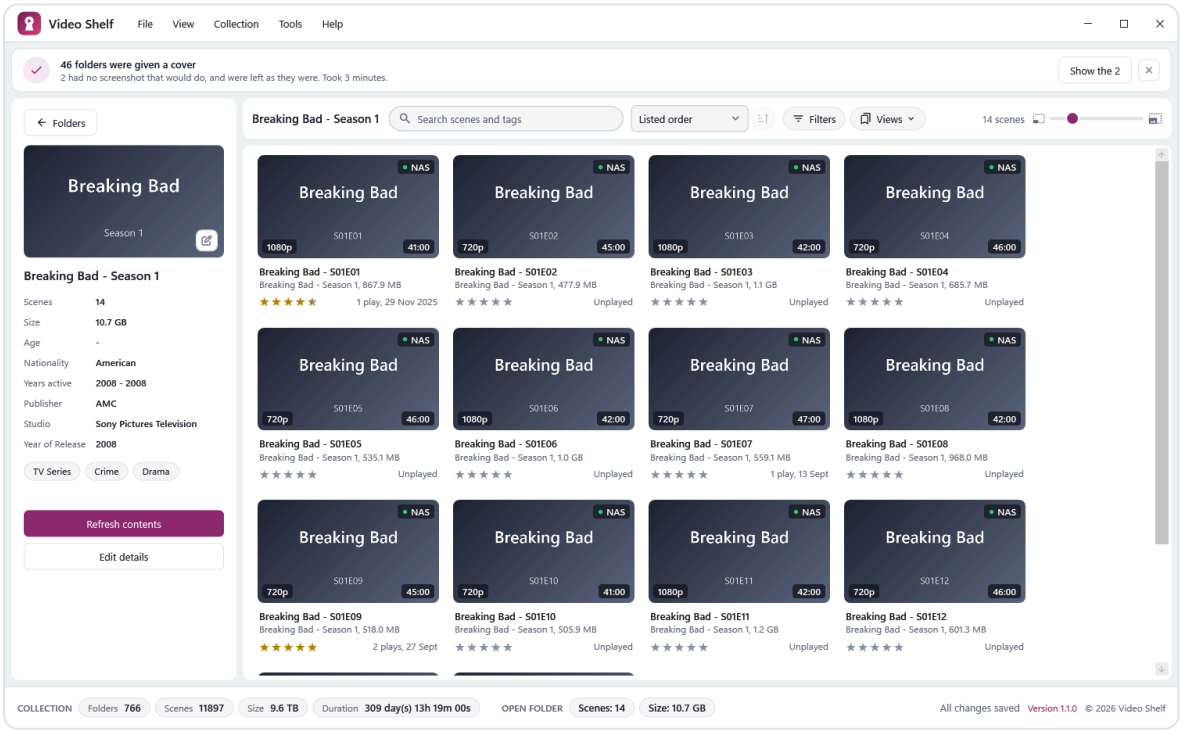
The activity panel

When the app works on many folders in the background, such as choosing covers for them, a panel appears below the menus. It shows what it's doing and which folder it's on, how many are done, about how long is left and the last one finished, with **Stop** to end it early.



Covers being chosen, shown in the activity panel

When it finishes, the panel says what happened. If anything was left out, a button such as **Show the 2** lists those folders. The panel goes by itself after a few seconds, unless the mouse is over it.



The activity panel once the covers are chosen

The status bar

The bar along the bottom shows the size of your collection, the folder that's open, and whether your changes are saved. Changes save by themselves every few minutes, and **Save now** saves straight away. At the right is the version you have: click it to see what's new.

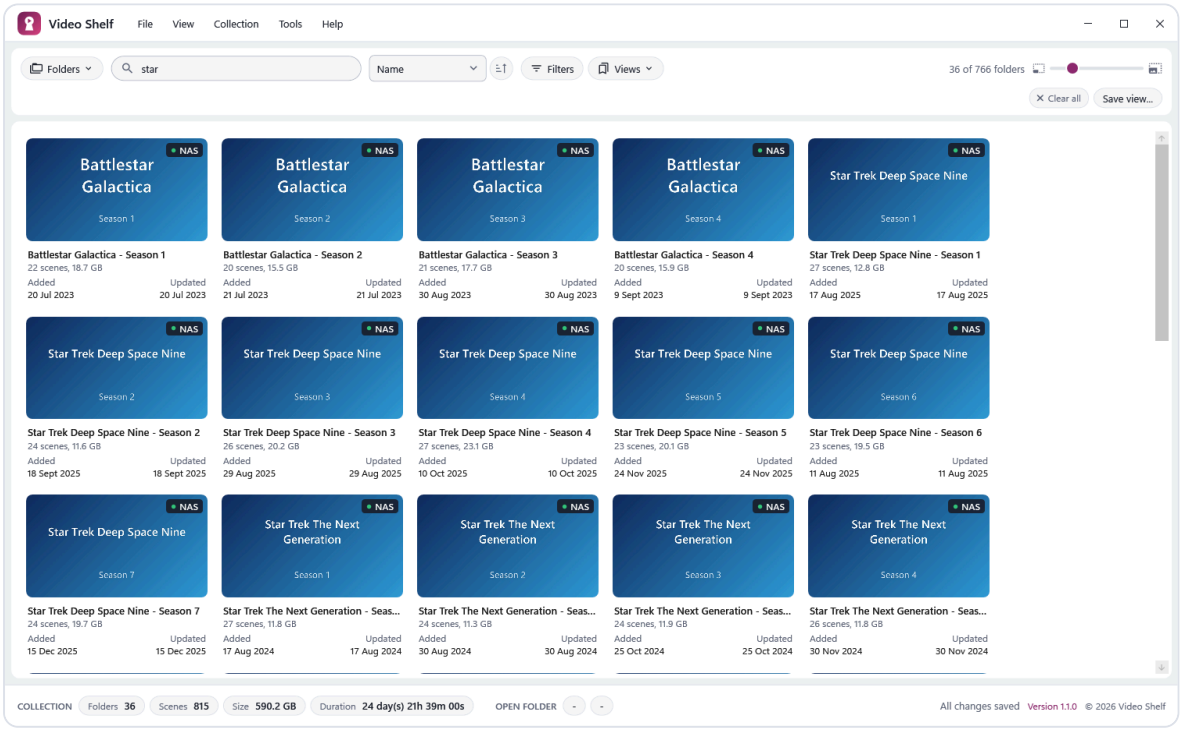
4. Finding folders

The filter bar

The same bar sits above every list of tiles, in the same order: search, sort, **Filters**, **Views**, how many are shown, and the tile size at the far right. Everything applies as soon as you change it.

Control	What it does
Search	Matches folder names, drive labels, performers and tags. Start a word with a minus sign to leave out anything that matches it
Sort	Orders the tiles, for example by name, scenes, size or date added. The arrow beside it reverses the order
Filters	Opens the filters, with a count of how many are in use
Views	Your saved views and the ready-made lists
Tile size	Makes the tiles bigger or smaller. **Ctrl** and the mouse wheel over the tiles does the same

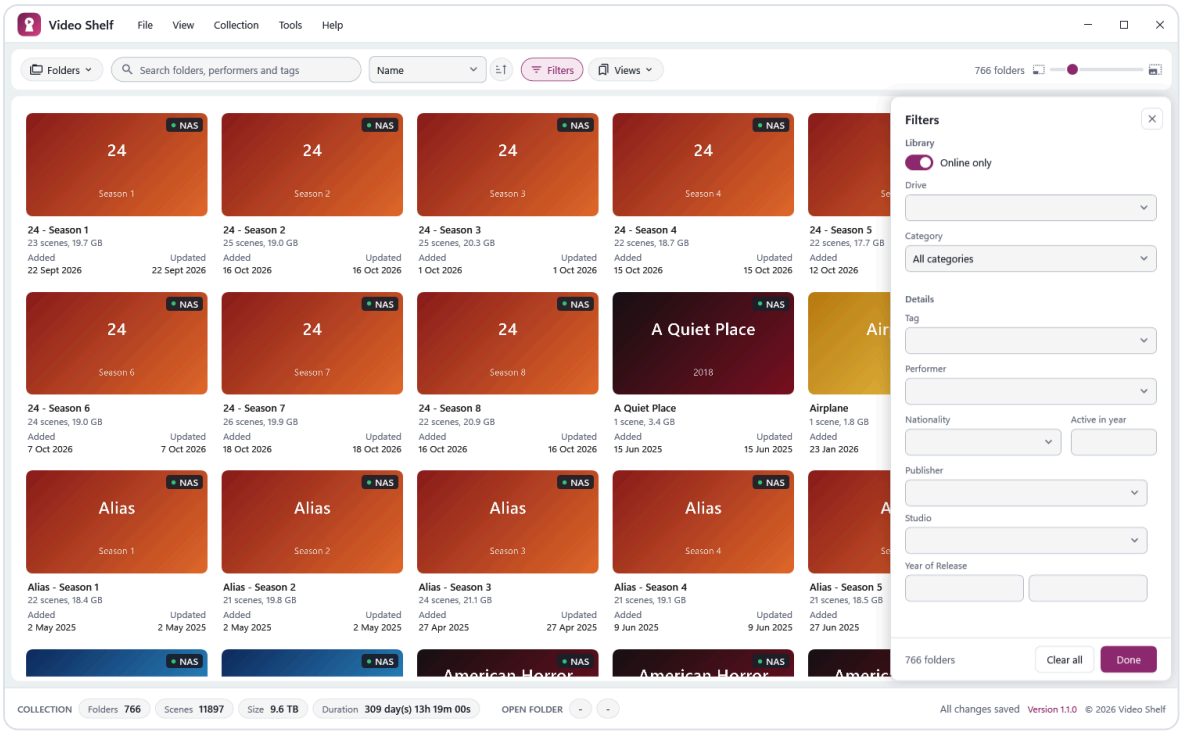
You type	You get
`star`	Folders matching "star"
`star -trek`	Folders matching "star", leaving out any that match "trek"



Folders matching a search

Filters

Click **Filters**, or press **Ctrl+Shift+F**, to open the filters beside the tiles.



The folder filters

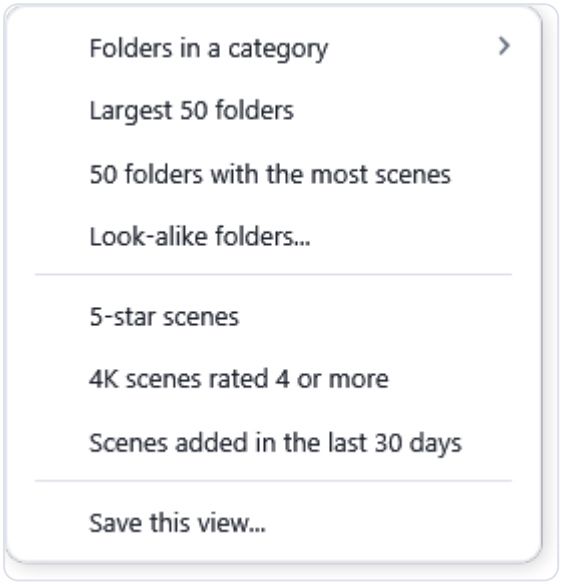
Filter	What it does
Online only	Shows only folders whose drive is connected
Drive	Shows one drive's folders
Category	Shows one category. See chapter 8. Hidden categories can be switched on here too
Tag	Shows folders with a chosen tag
Performer, **Nationality**, **Active in year**	Narrow folders by their performer details
Your attributes	Each attribute you've added, such as Publisher or Year of Release, becomes a filter here

Each filter in use also appears as a chip under the bar. Click a chip's cross to remove that filter, or **Clear all** to remove them all. **Esc** closes the filters.

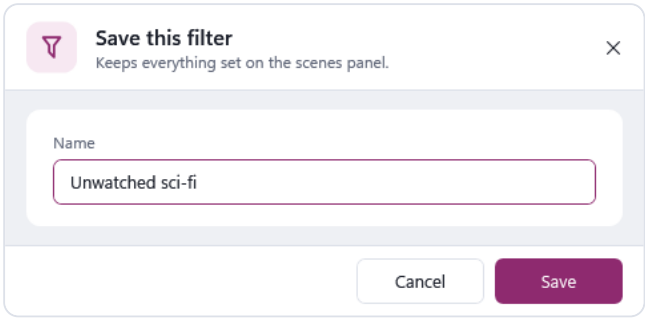
Views and ready-made lists

Views holds your saved views and some useful lists, such as the largest 50 folders, the 50 with the most scenes, folders in a category, 5-star scenes, 4K scenes rated 4 or more, scenes added in the last 30 days, and look-alike folders (see chapter 10).

To save the way you've set things up, choose **Save this view...** and give it a name. A view keeps the search, sort, filters and tile size, and appears at the top of the menu, ready for one click. **Delete a saved view** removes one.



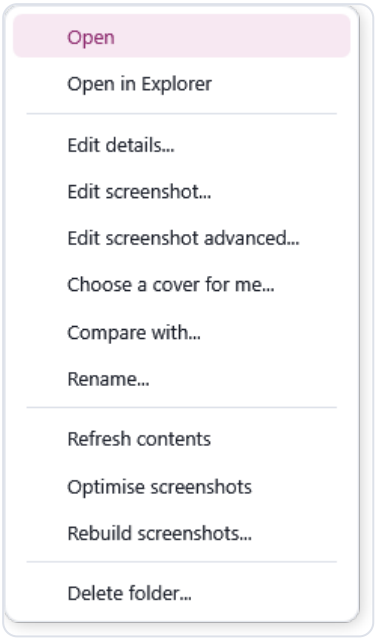
The Views menu



Naming a saved view

The folder menu

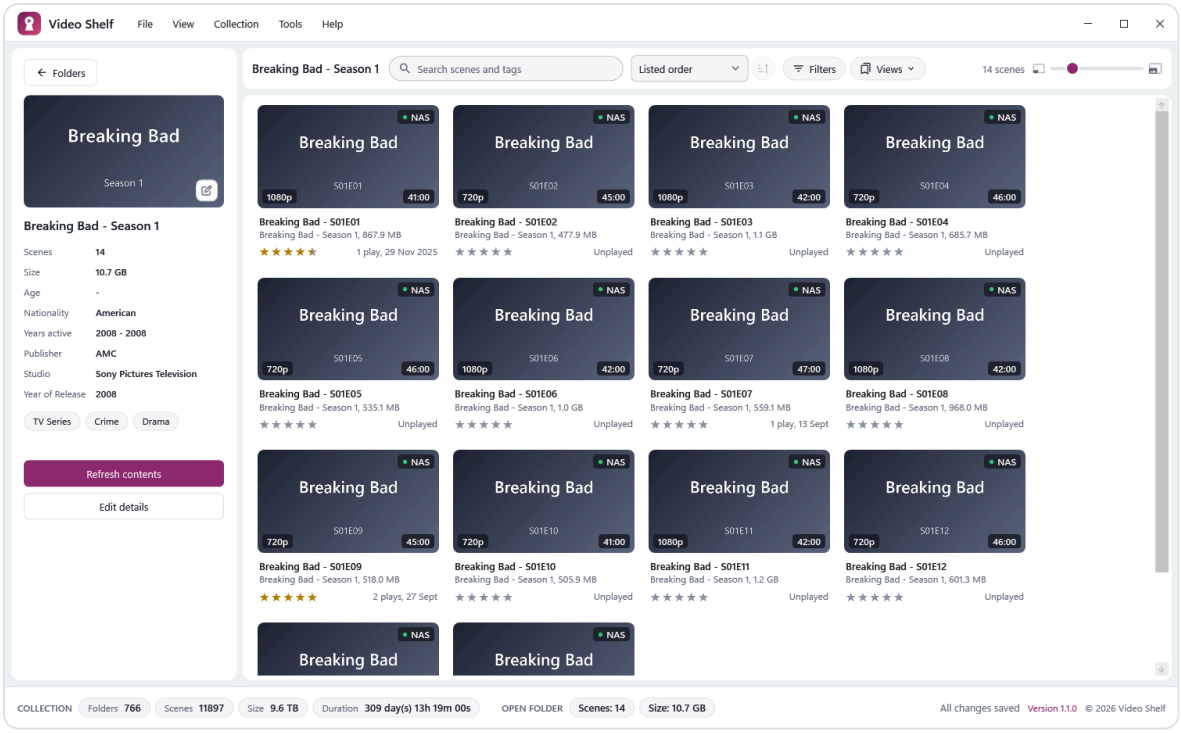
Right-click a folder tile for everything you can do to that folder: open it, open it in File Explorer, edit its details or cover, have a cover chosen for you, compare it with another folder, rename it, refresh it, optimise or rebuild its screenshots, and remove it from your collection.



Right-clicking a folder

5. Working with scenes

Click a folder tile to open it. Its details appear on the left, with its scenes beside them. **Folders** at the top left takes you back.



An open folder with its details and scenes

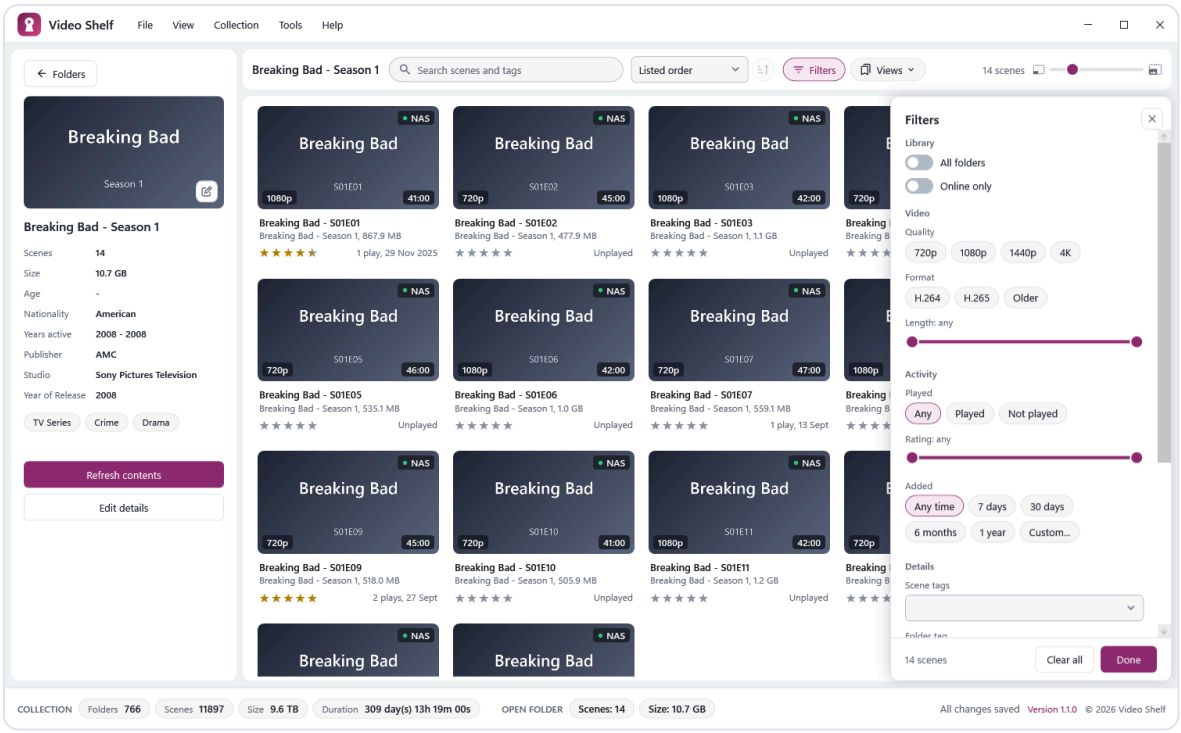
Playing and previewing

- **Play a scene** by clicking its picture. It opens in your default video player, and your play count goes up.
- **Preview a scene** by moving the mouse across its picture from left to right. You'll see moments from through the video.
- **Rate a scene** by clicking a star. Click the left half for half a star, or your current rating again to clear it.

Each tile shows the scene's quality and length on its picture, and its size, plays and when it was last played below. Right-click a scene for more, including its details, trimming it and deleting it.

Filtering scenes

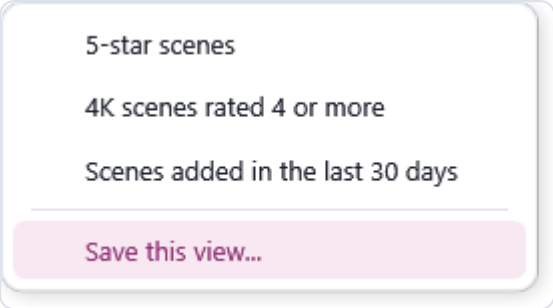
The scenes have the same filter bar as the folders. Search matches scene names and tags, and **Filters** opens these:



The scene filters

Filter	What it does
All folders	Searches every scene instead of the open folder
Online only	Shows scenes whose drive is connected
Quality and **Format**	Limit scenes by picture size and video type
Length	A range, from the shortest to the longest you want
Played	Any, only played, or only those not played yet
Rating	A range of star ratings
Added	Any time, the last 7 or 30 days, 6 months, a year, or dates of your own
Scene tags, **Folder tag** and your attributes	Limit scenes by tag or detail. A scene matches if it has any of the chosen tags

Views works as it does for folders: save the scene filters you use most, or pick a ready-made list.



The scenes' Views menu

Search every scene

Choose **All scenes** from the first button on the filter bar to search and filter your whole collection at once.

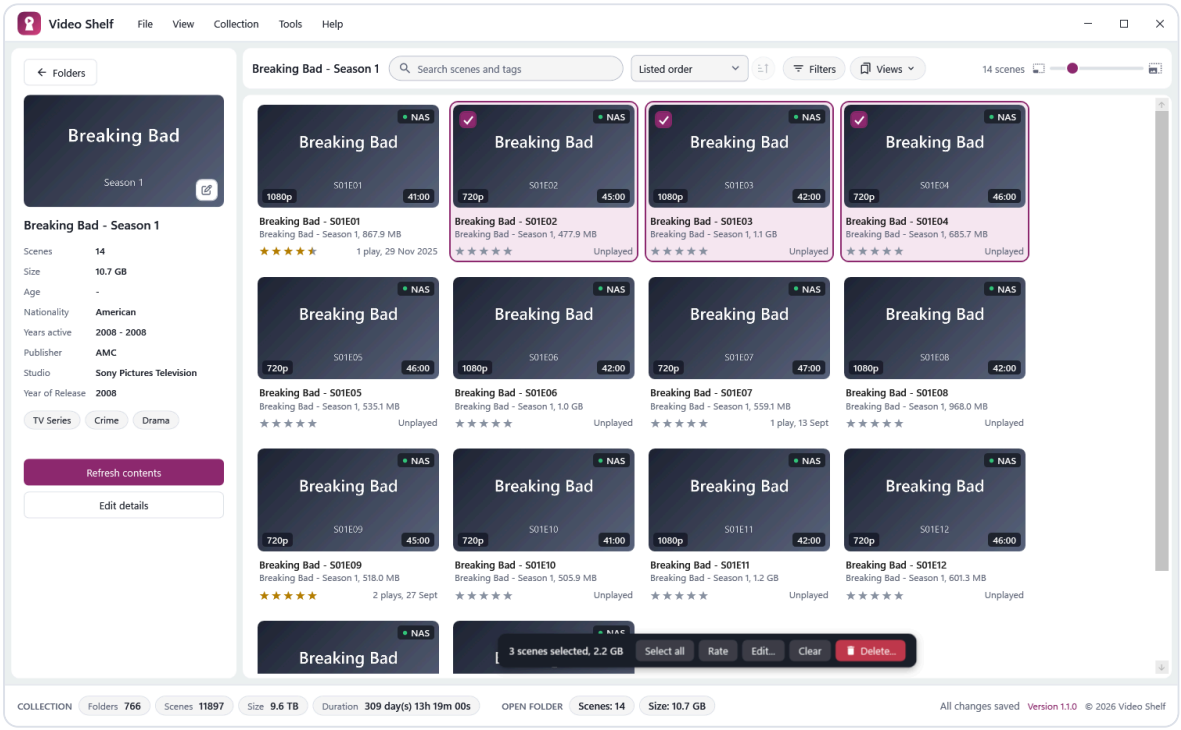
6. Working with many at once

Picking scenes

You can pick scenes in several ways. A bar then appears at the bottom of the list, with what you can do to them.

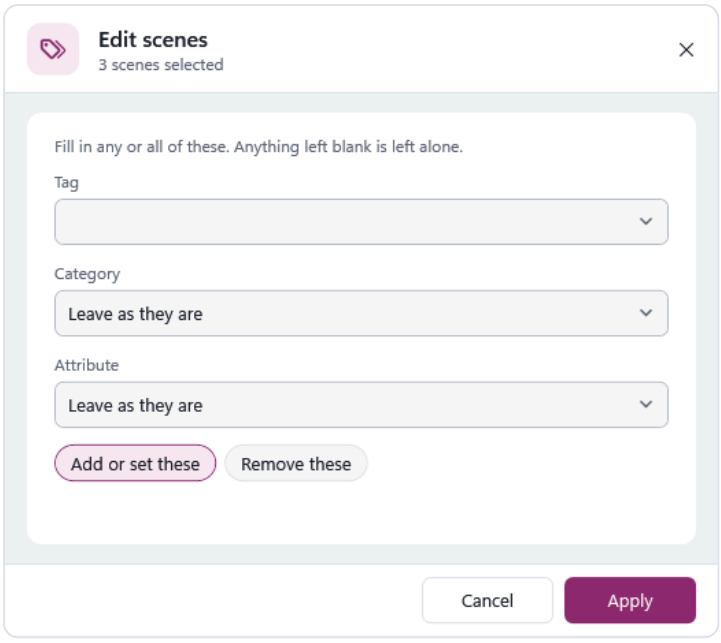
To pick	Do this
One scene	Click the tick box that appears on its tile
Several	Hold **Ctrl** and click each one
A run	Hold **Shift** and click the last one
An area	Drag a rectangle over the tiles, as you would in File Explorer
Everything shown	Press **Ctrl+A**
Nothing	Press **Esc**

Once anything is picked, clicking a tile picks it too, rather than playing it.



Three scenes picked, with the bar at the bottom

From the bar you can pick all, rate the scenes, edit their tags, categories and attributes, or delete them. **Clear** lets them go.



Editing tags, categories and attributes across the picked scenes

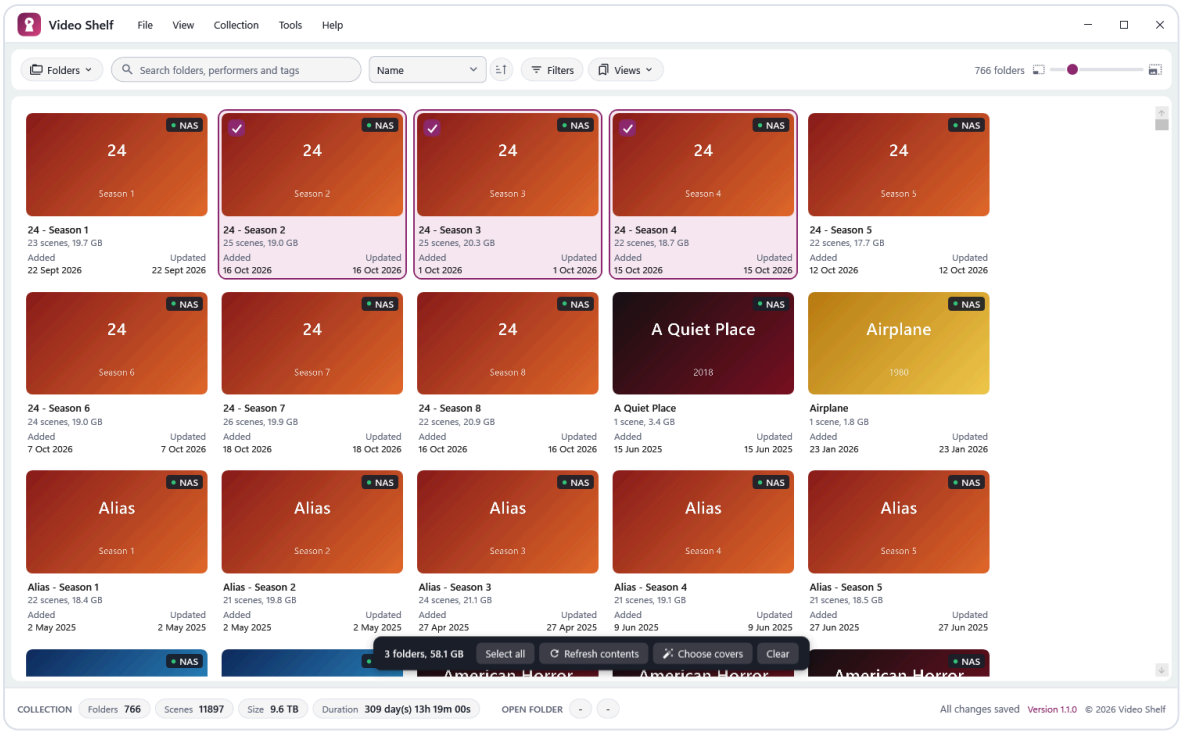
Deleting removes the file

Deleting a scene removes the video from its drive. Files go to the Recycle Bin where the drive has one. Windows has no Recycle Bin on some removable and network drives, so a delete there is permanent. Video Shelf always asks first, and says which kind it will be.

Picking folders

Folders can be picked in the same ways. The bar that appears offers:

- **Refresh contents** for all of them, skipping any whose drive isn't connected.
- **Choose covers**, giving each the best match among its screenshots. If some already have a cover, you're asked whether to replace those too.
- **Compare**, when exactly two are picked. See chapter 10.

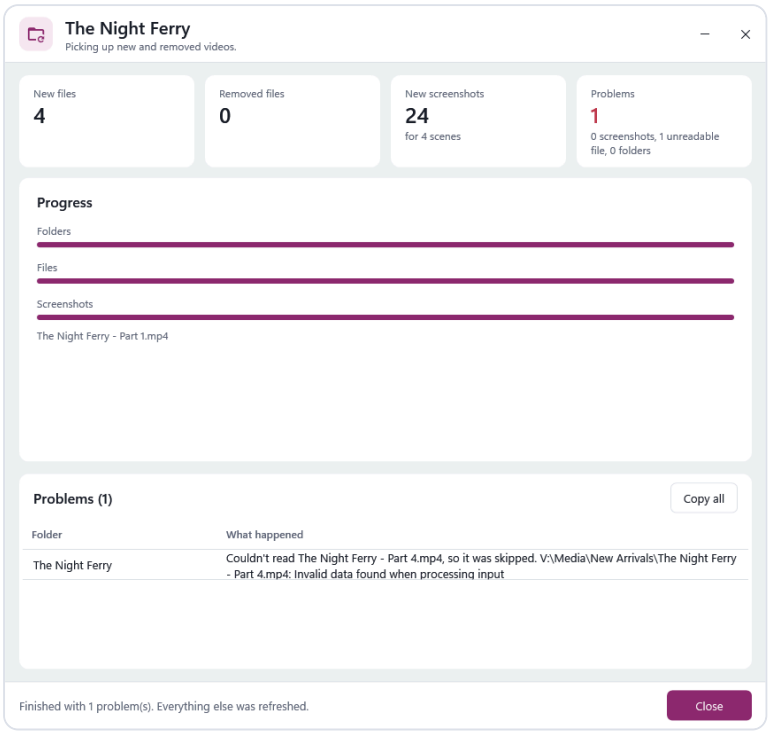


Three folders picked, with the folder bar

7. Keeping your collection up to date

Refreshing folders

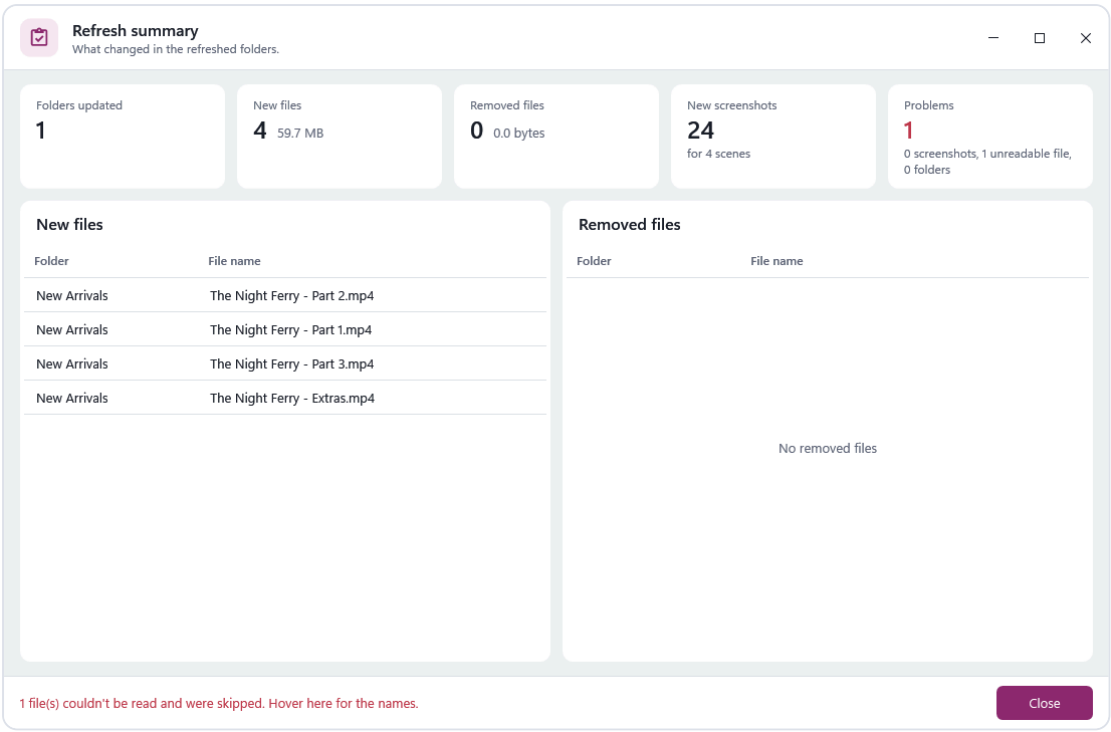
When videos change on disk, refresh to bring the catalogue up to date. Refresh one folder by right-clicking it, several by picking them, or every connected drive with **Collection > Refresh All Available Folders**.



A finished refresh, with one damaged file reported

Tile	What it counts
New files	Scenes added to the catalogue
Removed files	Scenes no longer on disk
New screenshots	Screenshots taken, for new scenes or for existing scenes that were missing them
Problems	Screenshots that failed, files that couldn't be read, and folders that couldn't be reached

A summary shows what changed when it finishes. If anything went wrong, the Refresh window stays open so you can read the details or use **Copy all**.



The refresh summary

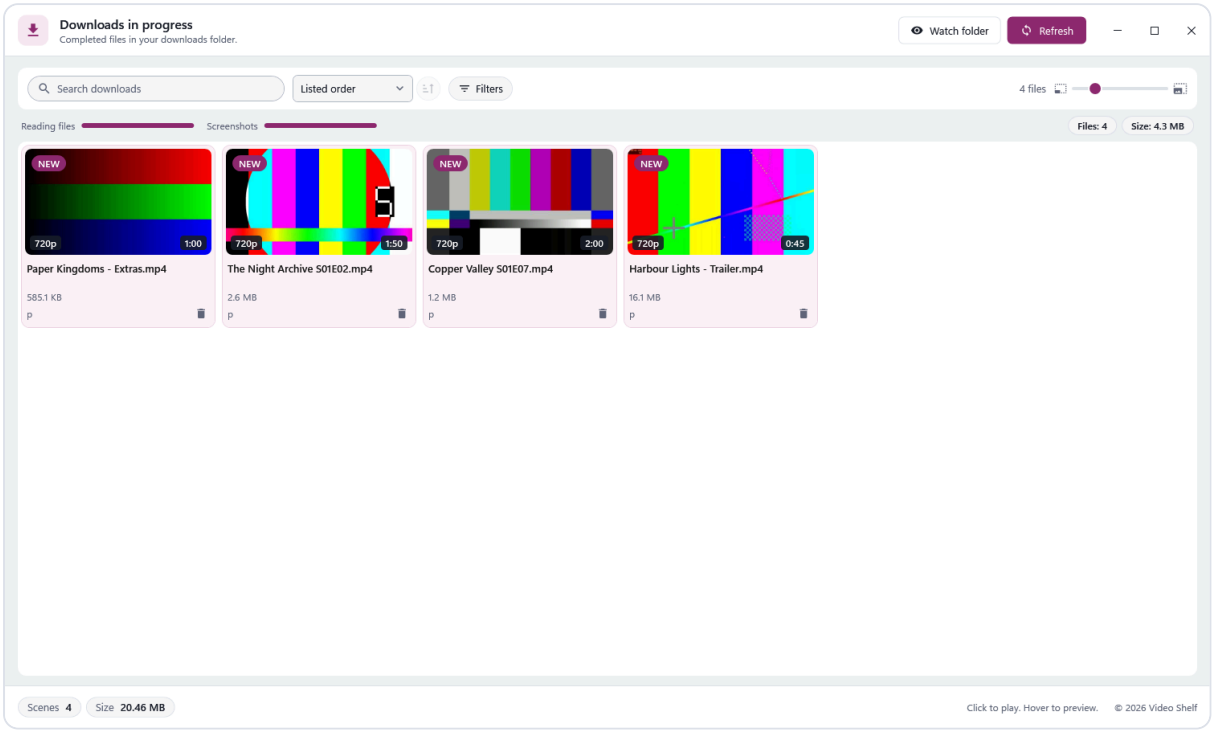
Damaged videos

A file that can't be read is skipped, and everything else carries on. Your catalogue isn't affected.

Downloads

File > Downloads... shows completed videos in the `p` folder inside your Windows Downloads folder, so you can review them before they join your collection. Move the mouse across a tile to preview it, or click to play. New files are marked, and screenshots are taken in advance to save time when you import them. **Refresh** reads the folder again, and **Watch folder** picks up new files as they arrive.

Downloads has the same filter bar as the main window, with search, sort, length and the folders to include or leave out.

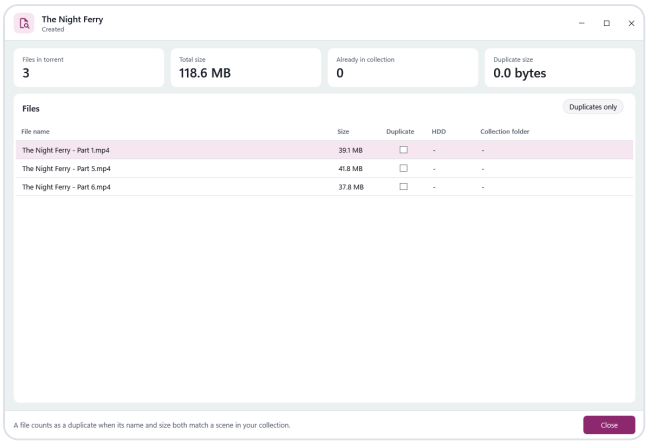


The Downloads window

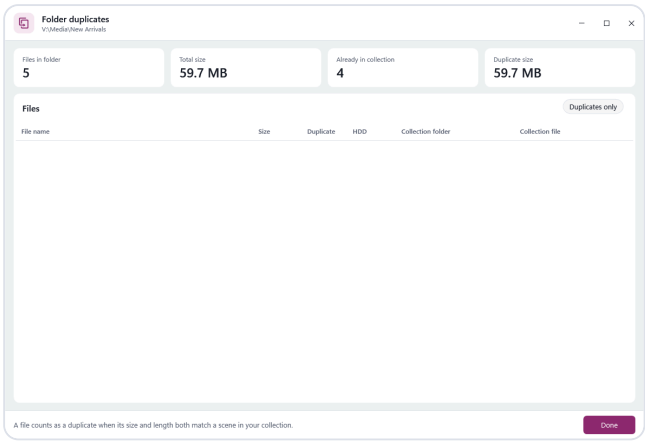
Checking new files against your collection

These two tools show what you already have before you add more.

- **Tools > Torrent Check...** reads a torrent file and marks anything already in your catalogue.
- **Tools > Folder Duplicates...** compares a folder on disk with your catalogue.



Torrent Check

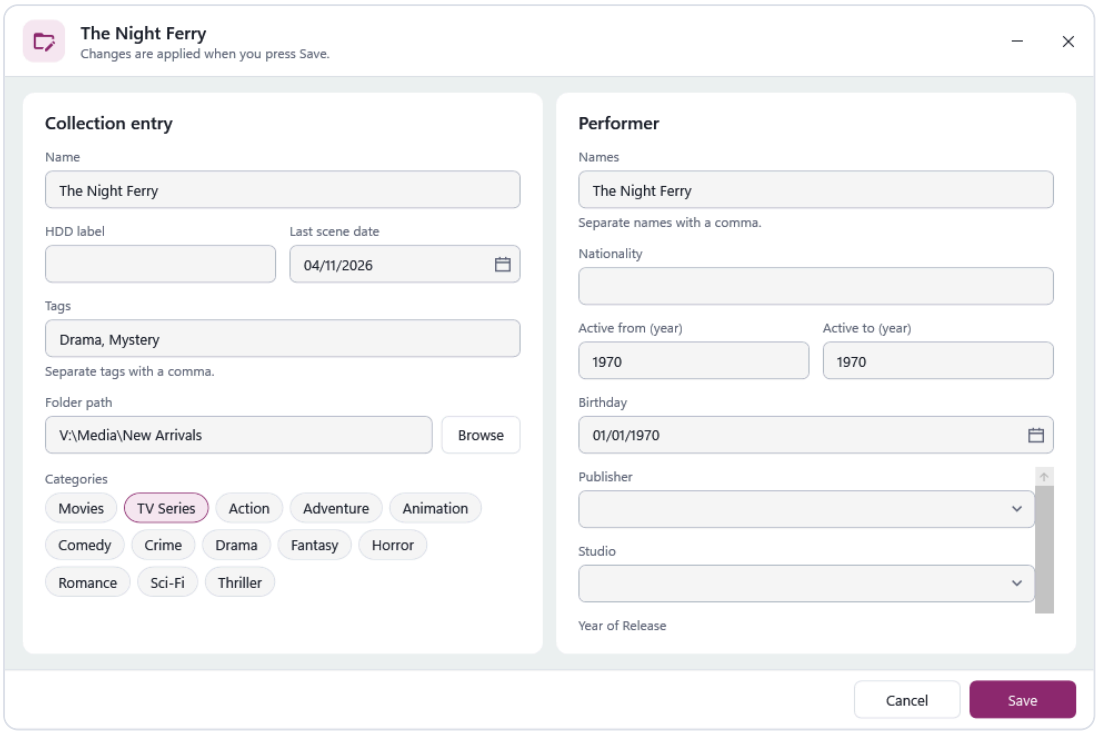


Folder Duplicates, with four files already in the collection

8. Organising your collection

Folder details

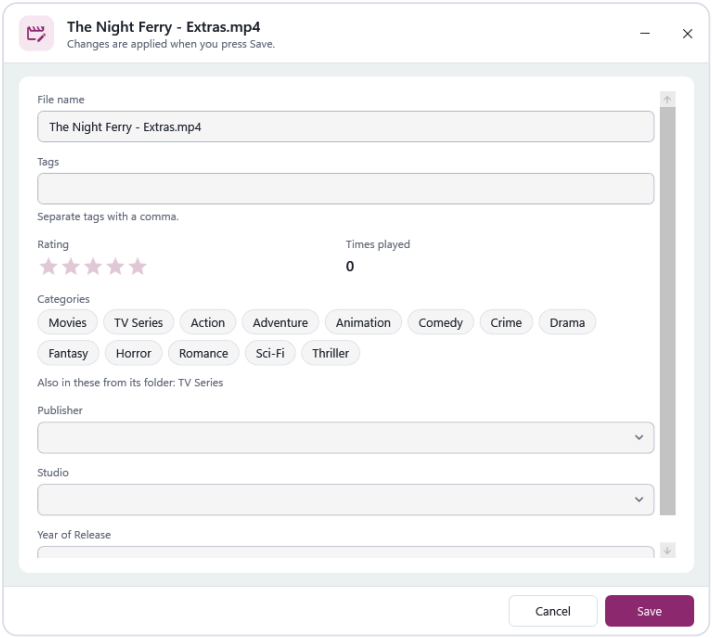
Right-click a folder and choose **Edit details...**, or click **Edit details** beside an open folder, to change its name, drive label, tags, categories, performer details and your own attributes. Changes apply when you click **Save**.



The Edit Folder Details window

Scene details

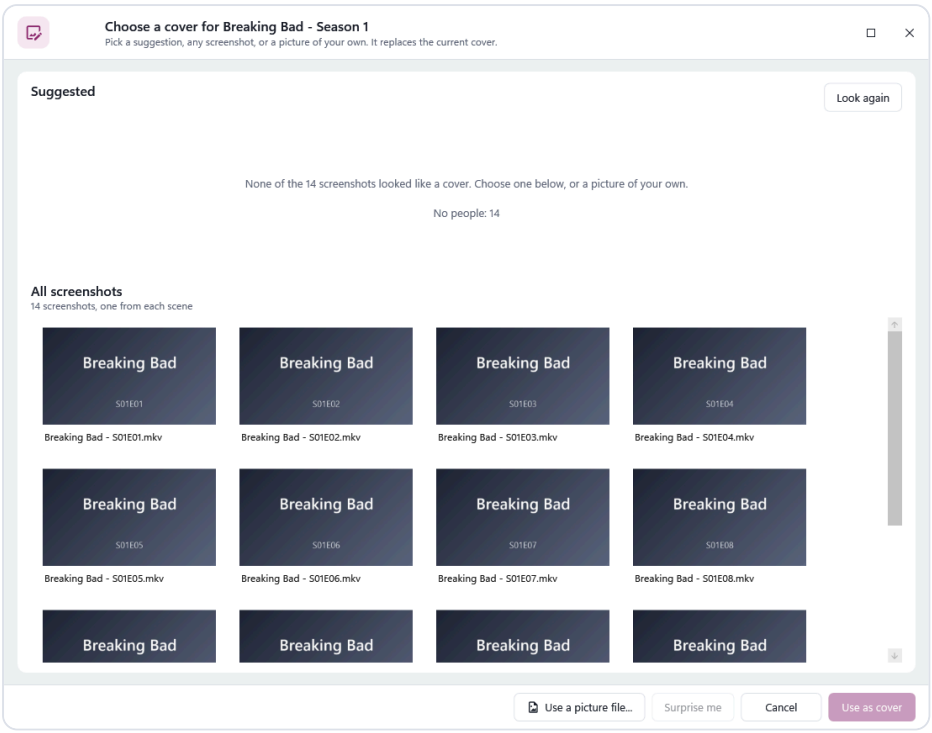
Right-click a scene and choose **Scene info...** to change its name, tags, rating, categories and attributes.



The Scene Details window

Covers

A folder's cover is the picture on its tile. To change it, right-click the folder and choose **Edit screenshot...**, or click the pencil on the cover of an open folder.



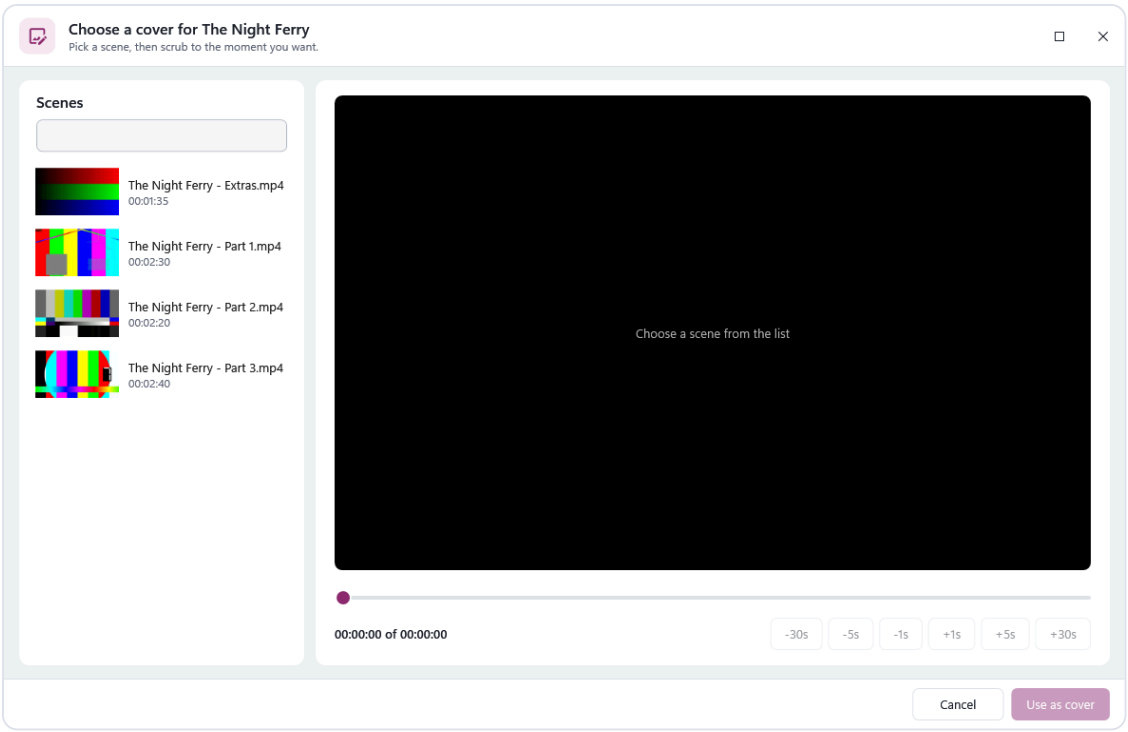
Choosing a cover

- **Suggested** shows the screenshots the cover model rates best, if you've downloaded one (see chapter 12). It prefers one person to two, two to three, filling as much of the picture as possible, and leaves out black frames, title cards and credits. Suggestions are remembered for 30 days, so the window opens straight away next time. **Look again** looks afresh.
- **All screenshots** shows the first screenshot of every scene, to choose from by eye.
- **Use a picture file...** uses a picture of your own, such as one you've downloaded.
- **Surprise me** picks one of the suggestions at random.

Choose a cover for me... on the folder menu opens the same window. When the screenshots don't suit a cover, as with the drawn posters in this guide, the window says so and you choose one yourself. To give many folders a cover at once, pick them and use **Choose covers** on the bar. The activity panel shows how it's going.

For more control, **Edit screenshot advanced...** lets you choose any moment of any of the folder's scenes, at up to 1920 by 1080. Its drive must be connected.

Some folders suit no cover at all, such as a collection from one producer. Right-click the folder and choose **Remove cover...**, or click **No cover** in the cover window. Its tile then shows the folder's initial, and covers chosen automatically or for many folders at once leave it alone, even when you choose to replace existing covers. Choosing a cover for it yourself gives it one again.



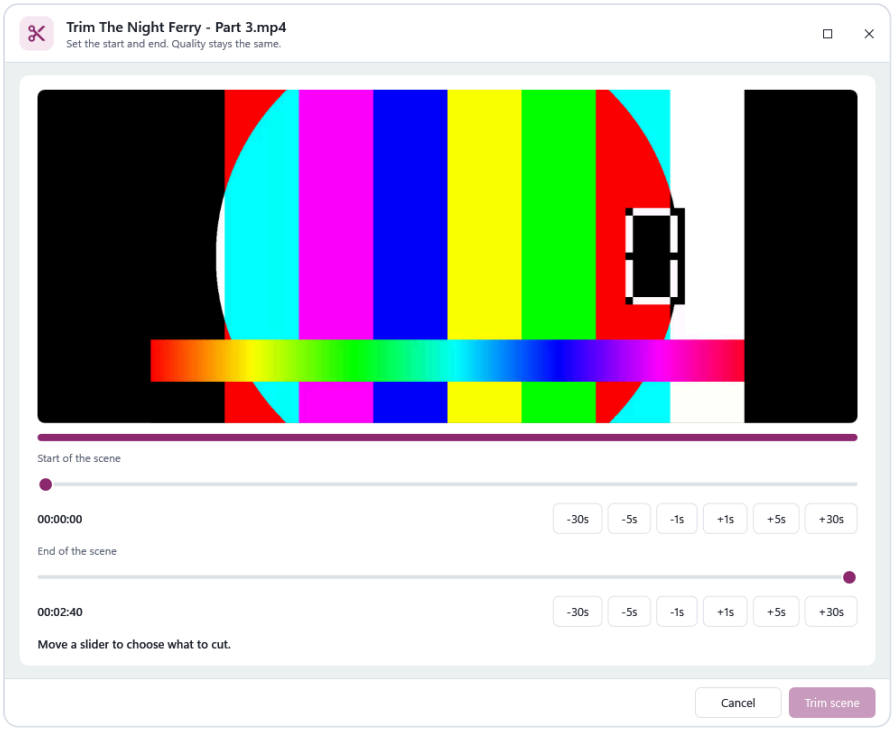
Choosing a cover from any moment of a scene

Trimming a scene

To cut an unwanted intro or ending from a video, right-click the scene and choose **Trim scene...**. Its drive must be connected. Move the sliders, or use the step buttons, to choose where the scene starts and ends, using the picture as a guide. The scene keeps its name, rating, plays and details, and it's given new screenshots.

The video isn't re-encoded, so its quality doesn't change. A video can only start on certain frames, though, so the cut may land a few seconds before your mark. The window shows the frame it will really start on.

The new file is written and checked first, so the drive needs room for it. The original then goes to the Recycle Bin, and the space comes back when you empty the bin. On a drive with no Recycle Bin the original is deleted permanently, and the window says so before you commit.



Trim Scene

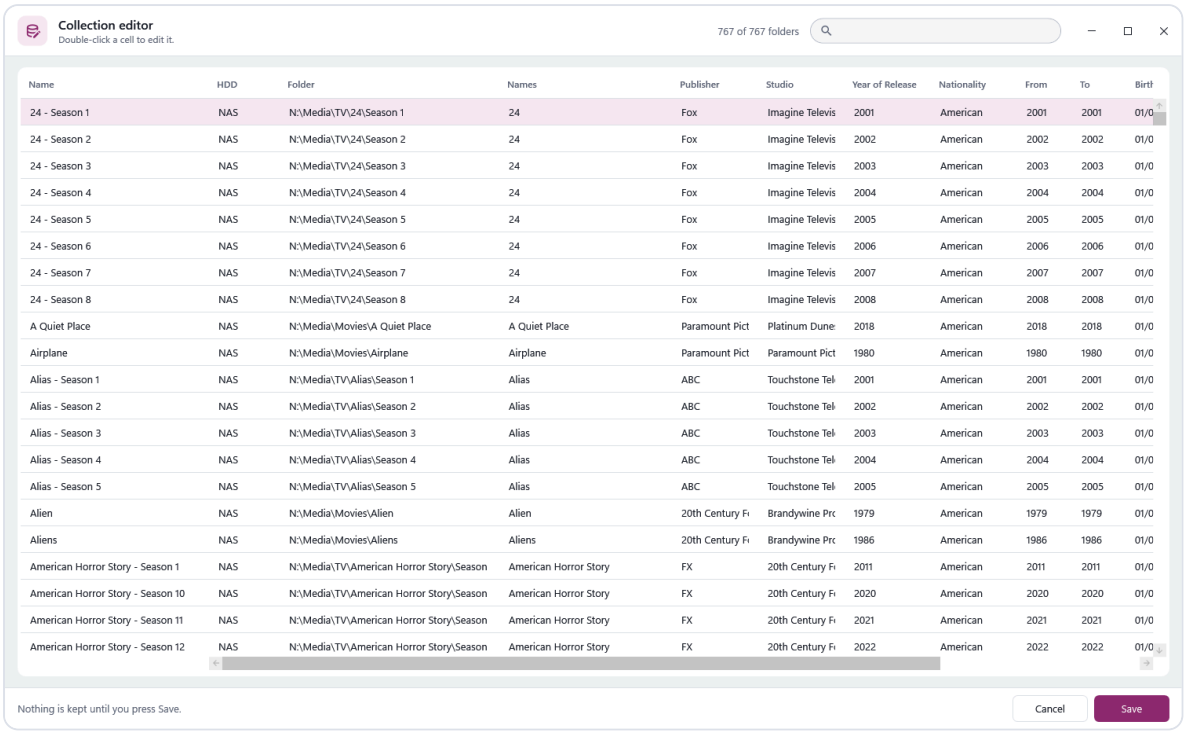
Categories

Categories are your own groups for folders and scenes, such as Movies and TV Series, or genres. A folder can be in several. Create them in **Settings > Categories**, and tick them in Edit Folder Details.

Setting	Effect
Hidden	The category's folders stay out of the folders list, Home and Surprise me until you switch the category on in the filters
Switched off	The category and its scenes disappear from the whole app, except Settings

Collection Editor

Collection > Collection Editor... shows every folder in a table, which is the quickest way to update many at once. Search to narrow the list, edit in place, then save.



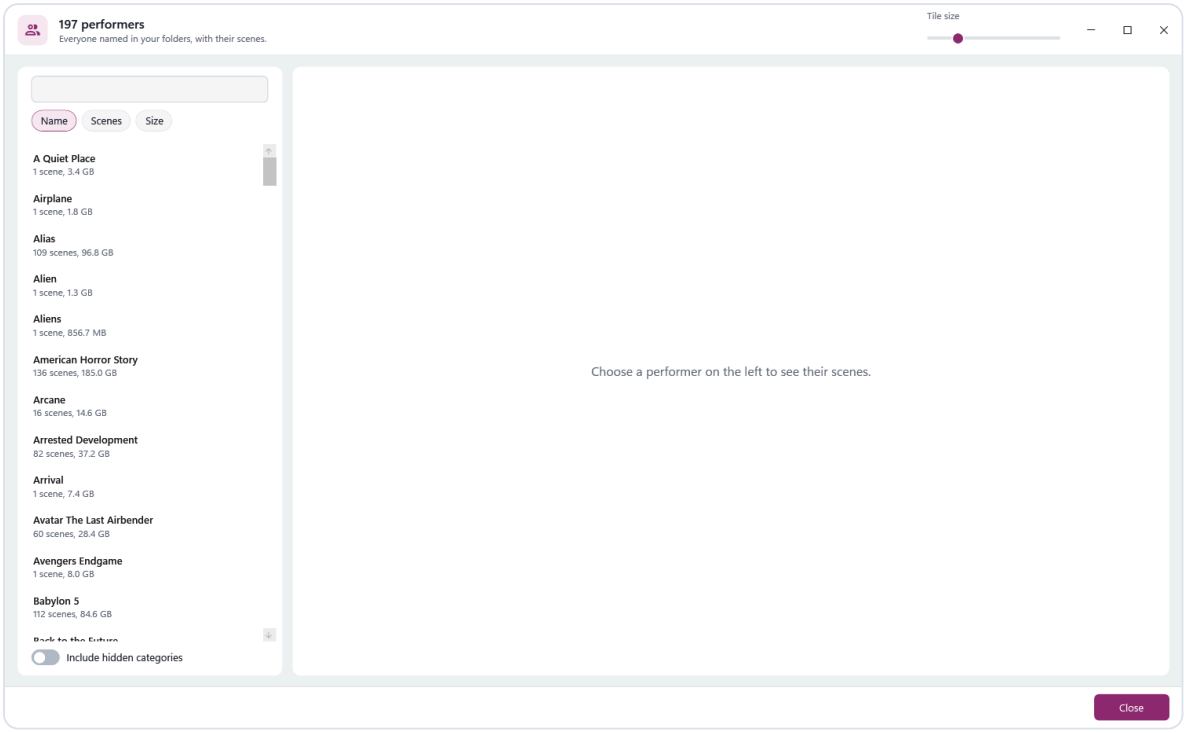
Name	HDD	Folder	Names	Publisher	Studio	Year of Release	Nationality	From	To	Birth
24 - Season 1	NAS	N:\Media\TV\24\Season 1	24	Fox	Imagine Televis	2001	American	2001	2001	01/0
24 - Season 2	NAS	N:\Media\TV\24\Season 2	24	Fox	Imagine Televis	2002	American	2002	2002	01/0
24 - Season 3	NAS	N:\Media\TV\24\Season 3	24	Fox	Imagine Televis	2003	American	2003	2003	01/0
24 - Season 4	NAS	N:\Media\TV\24\Season 4	24	Fox	Imagine Televis	2004	American	2004	2004	01/0
24 - Season 5	NAS	N:\Media\TV\24\Season 5	24	Fox	Imagine Televis	2005	American	2005	2005	01/0
24 - Season 6	NAS	N:\Media\TV\24\Season 6	24	Fox	Imagine Televis	2006	American	2006	2006	01/0
24 - Season 7	NAS	N:\Media\TV\24\Season 7	24	Fox	Imagine Televis	2007	American	2007	2007	01/0
24 - Season 8	NAS	N:\Media\TV\24\Season 8	24	Fox	Imagine Televis	2008	American	2008	2008	01/0
A Quiet Place	NAS	N:\Media\Movies\A Quiet Place	A Quiet Place	Paramount Pict	Platinum Dune	2018	American	2018	2018	01/0
Airplane	NAS	N:\Media\Movies\Airplane	Airplane	Paramount Pict	Paramount Pict	1980	American	1980	1980	01/0
Alias - Season 1	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Alias\Season 1	Alias	ABC	Touchstone Tel	2001	American	2001	2001	01/0
Alias - Season 2	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Alias\Season 2	Alias	ABC	Touchstone Tel	2002	American	2002	2002	01/0
Alias - Season 3	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Alias\Season 3	Alias	ABC	Touchstone Tel	2003	American	2003	2003	01/0
Alias - Season 4	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Alias\Season 4	Alias	ABC	Touchstone Tel	2004	American	2004	2004	01/0
Alias - Season 5	NAS	N:\Media\TV\Alias\Season 5	Alias	ABC	Touchstone Tel	2005	American	2005	2005	01/0
Alien	NAS	N:\Media\Movies\Alien	Alien	20th Century Fo	Brandywine Pro	1979	American	1979	1979	01/0
Aliens	NAS	N:\Media\Movies\Aliens	Aliens	20th Century Fo	Brandywine Pro	1986	American	1986	1986	01/0
American Horror Story - Season 1	NAS	N:\Media\TV\American Horror Story\Season	American Horror Story	FX	20th Century Fo	2011	American	2011	2011	01/0
American Horror Story - Season 10	NAS	N:\Media\TV\American Horror Story\Season	American Horror Story	FX	20th Century Fo	2020	American	2020	2020	01/0
American Horror Story - Season 11	NAS	N:\Media\TV\American Horror Story\Season	American Horror Story	FX	20th Century Fo	2021	American	2021	2021	01/0
American Horror Story - Season 12	NAS	N:\Media\TV\American Horror Story\Season	American Horror Story	FX	20th Century Fo	2022	American	2022	2022	01/0

The Collection Editor

9. Exploring your collection

Performers

View > Performers... lists everyone in your collection, with their details and all their scenes.

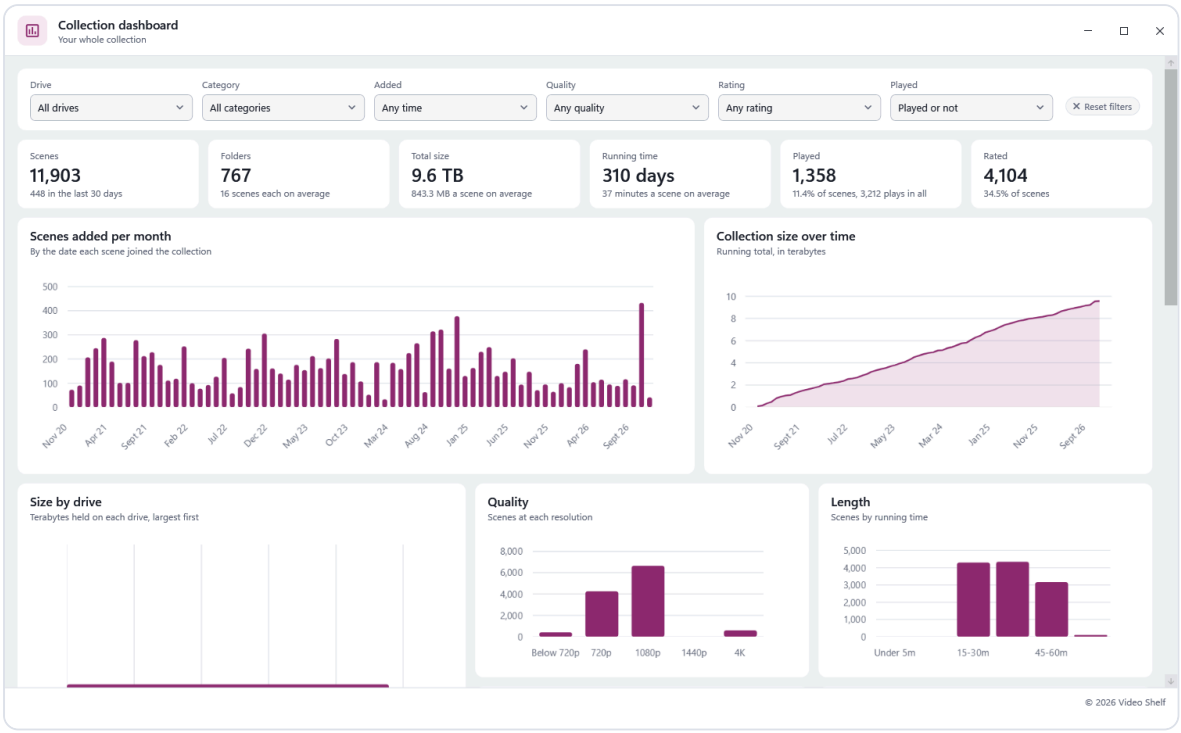


The Performers window

- Names come from each folder's performer details, or from the folder's name if those are empty.
- **Their folders** shows scenes in their own folders.
- **Elsewhere** shows scenes in other folders whose file names include their full name.
- Search, or sort by name, scene count or size.
- Hidden categories stay out of the list unless you switch on **Include hidden categories**.

Dashboard

View > Dashboard... opens a dashboard of your collection. Use the filters along the top to focus on one drive, category, period, quality, rating or play status, and every chart updates to match.

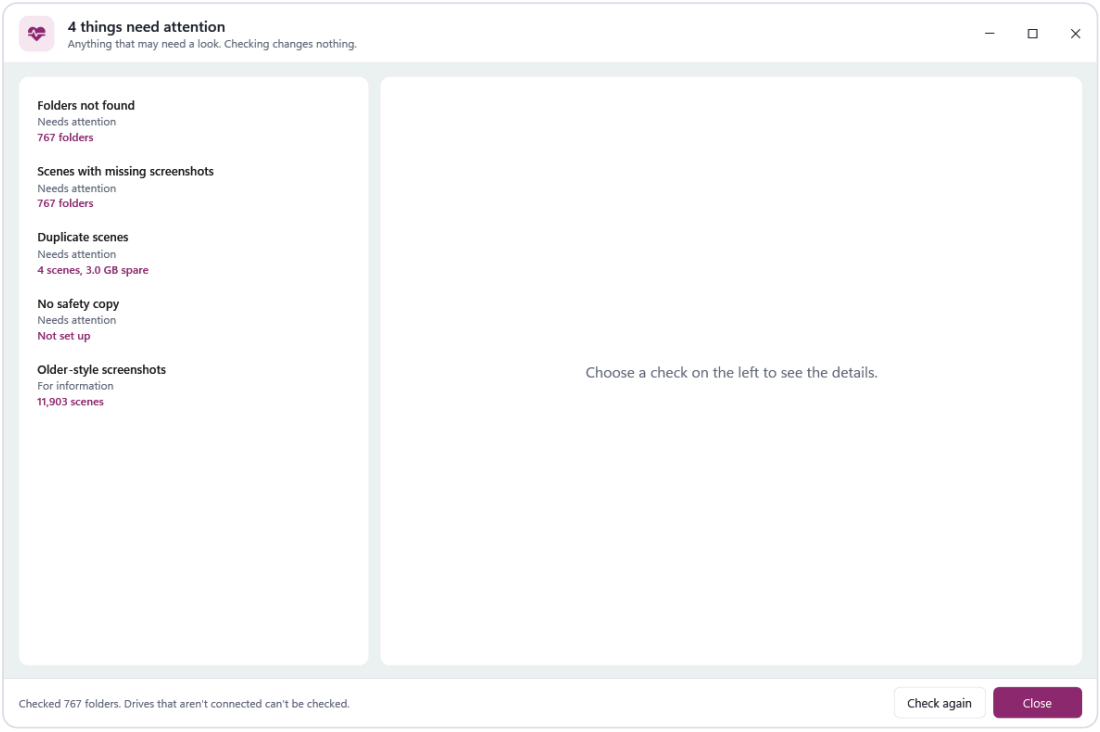


The Dashboard

10. Keeping things tidy

Collection Health

Collection > Collection Health... checks your whole collection and lists anything that may need attention. Checking changes nothing.



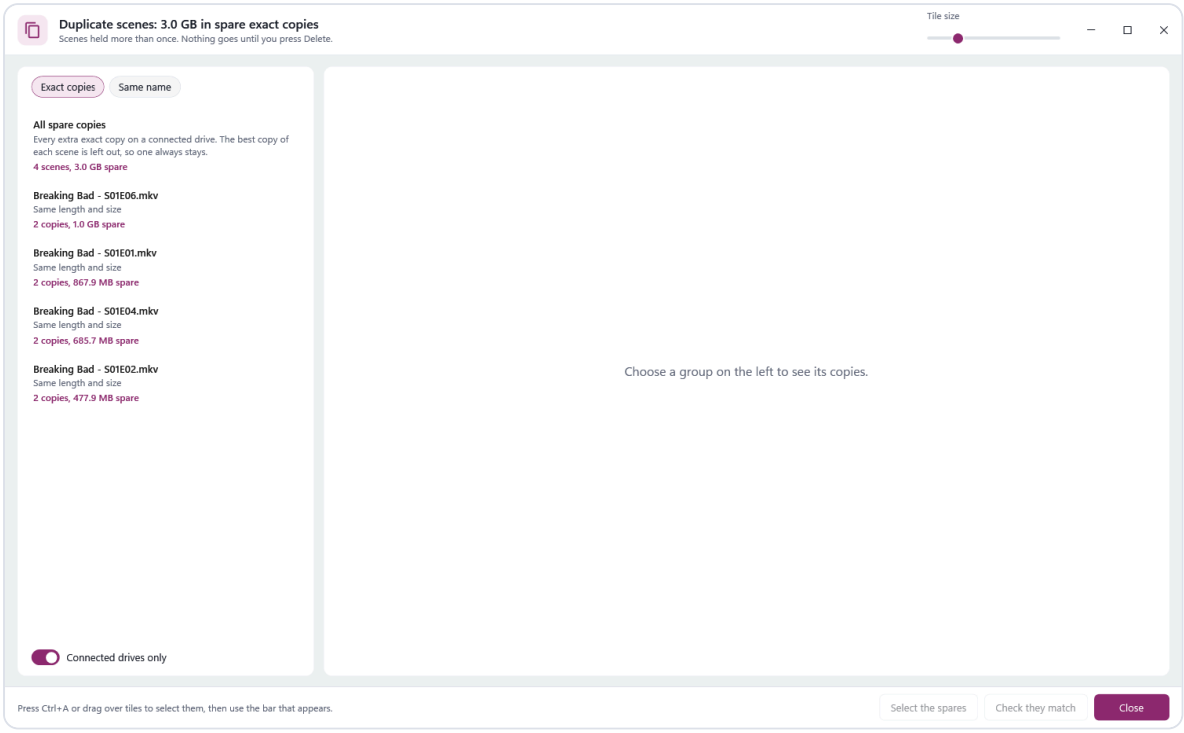
Collection Health

Choose a check on the left to see its details and, where it applies, a button that takes you to the fix.

Check	What it means
Problems from the last refresh	Files that couldn't be read, or screenshots that couldn't be taken
Folders not found	The drive is connected but the folder has moved
Missing screenshots	Refreshing the folder takes them again
Leftover screenshots	Screenshots of scenes no longer in your catalogue
Duplicate scenes	Scenes held more than once
Drives nearly full	Drives at 90% or more
Safety copy	Not set up, not found, or over 30 days old
Older-style screenshots	Scenes that Optimise Screenshots or Rebuild All Screenshots can bring up to date

Duplicate Scenes

Collection > Duplicate Scenes... finds scenes held more than once across your collection. The best copy of each is marked, going by rating, then plays or picture quality. Your Favourites folder is left out, as those copies are there on purpose.



Duplicate Scenes

Type	Meaning
Exact copies	The same length and the same size to the byte
Same name	The same name and length at different sizes, which is usually one scene encoded twice

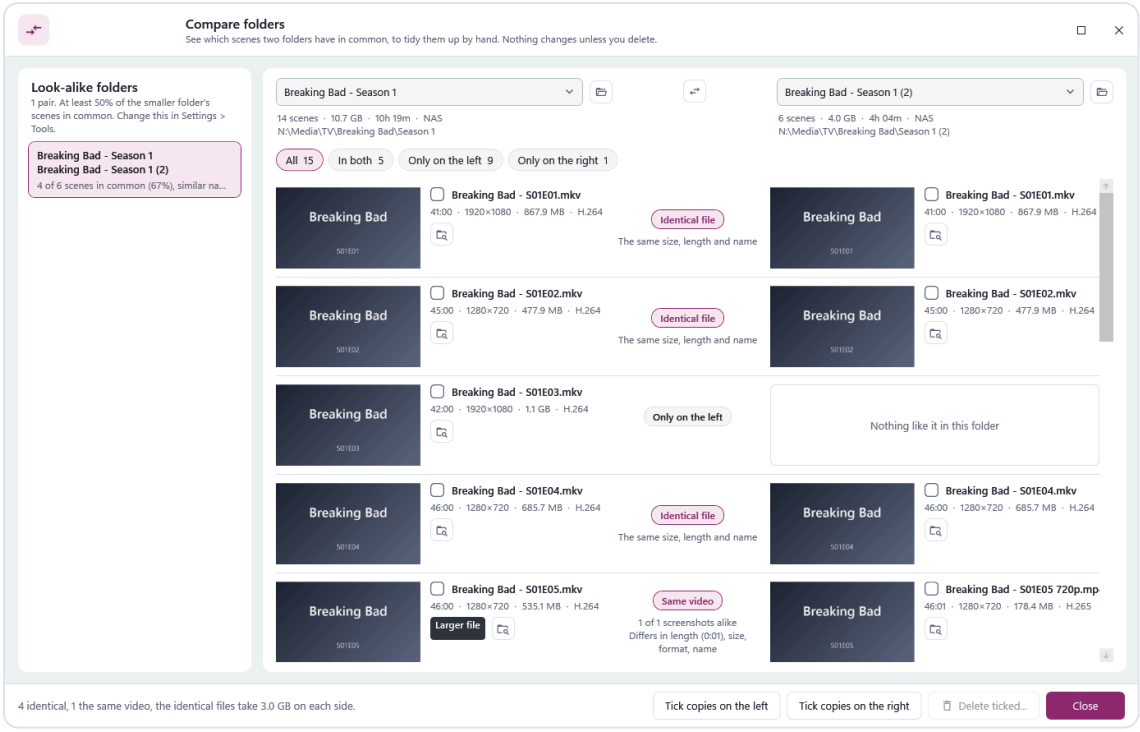
1. Choose a group on the left.
2. Click **Check they match** to compare samples from the files.
3. Click **Select the spares**, then use the bar that appears to delete them.

All spare copies lists every extra exact copy on your connected drives. The best copy of each scene is never included.

> **Check before deleting in bulk**
> Exact copies are matched from the catalogue, not by reading the files. Plays and tags on a deleted copy are lost, so start with a few groups.

Compare Folders

Sometimes the same videos end up in two folders, such as a season downloaded twice under different names. **Collection > Compare Folders...** shows two folders side by side, scene by scene, to help you tidy them up by hand. You can also right-click a folder and choose **Compare with...**, or pick two folders and click **Compare**.



Two copies of a season, compared

On the left are **look-alike folders**: pairs across your collection with enough scenes in common, the most in common first. Pick one to compare it. Each row pairs a scene with the one in the other folder it seems to be, going by the screenshots, names, lengths, sizes and dimensions:

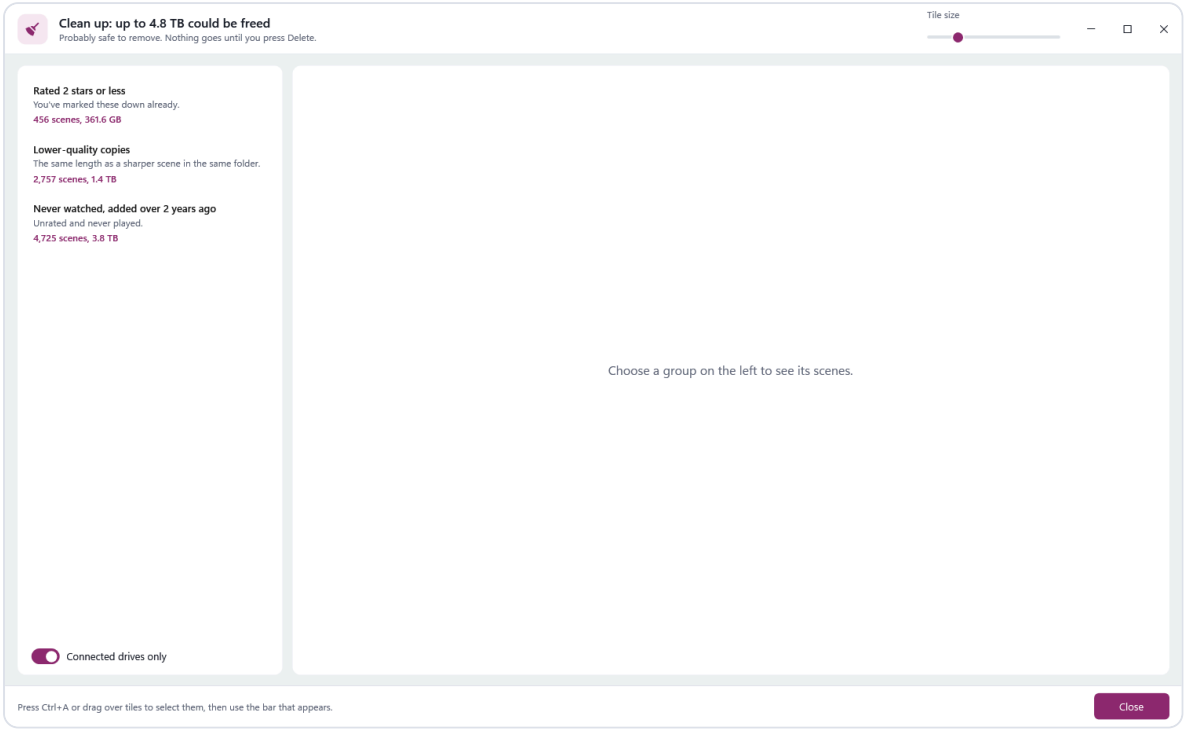
Verdict	Meaning
Identical file	The same size and length, even under another name
Same video	A close length and alike screenshots, such as a smaller copy. What differs is listed, and the better copy is marked
Maybe the same	The same name but a different length, or a similar name and length
Only on the left or **right**	Nothing like it in the other folder

Click a screenshot to play the scene, or the folder button to show it in File Explorer. Tick scenes to delete them, after asking, or use **Tick copies on the left** or **on the right** to tick the identical files on one side. Nothing else is changed: moving and merging are up to you. How much two folders must have in common to be listed is set in **Settings > Tools**.

Clean Up

Collection > Clean Up... suggests scenes you may want to remove, such as low ratings, lower-quality copies, very low resolution, old scenes you've never watched, and very short clips. Your 4 and 5-star scenes are never suggested.

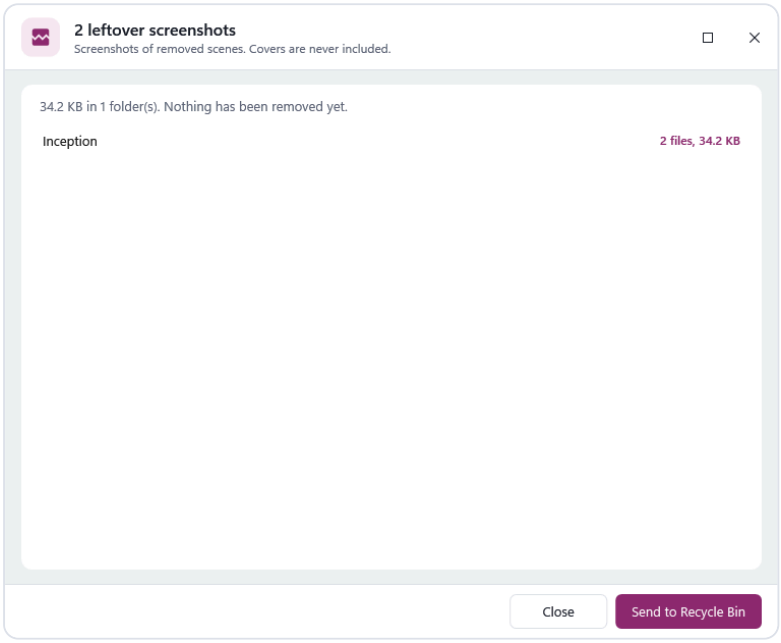
Choose a group, press **Ctrl+A** to pick its scenes, and use the bar that appears.



Clean Up

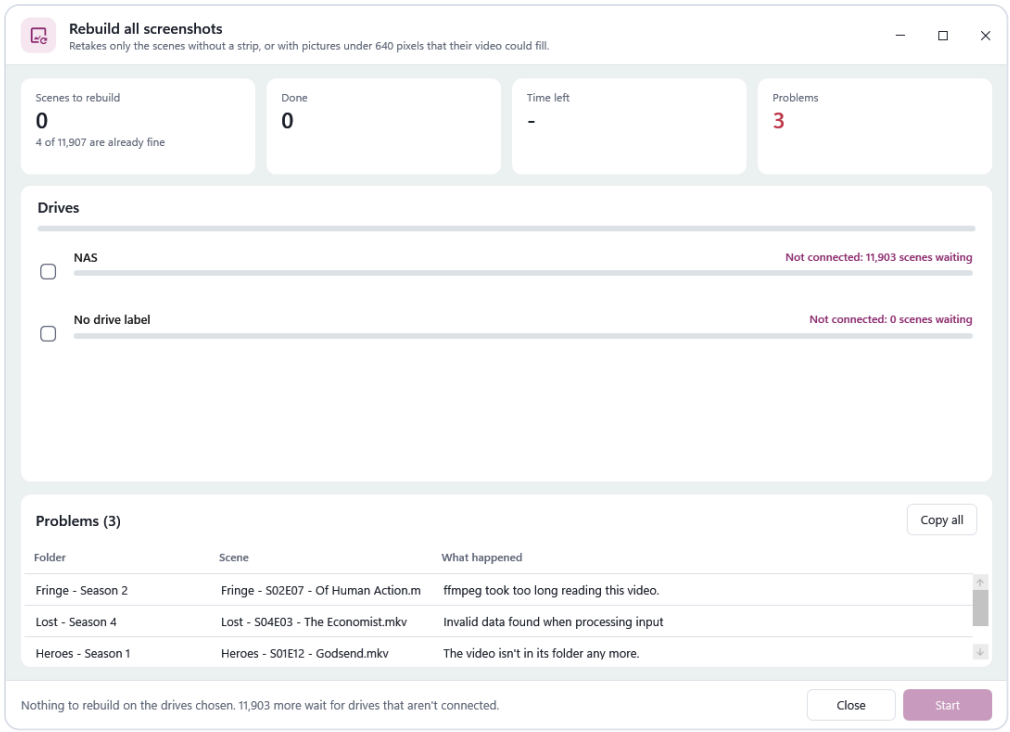
Screenshot tools

Tool	Use it to
Tools > Screenshot Leftovers...	Find screenshots of scenes that have gone, and send them to the Recycle Bin
Rebuild screenshots... (right-click a folder)	Take new screenshots for a folder. Its drive must be connected, and its cover is kept
Collection > Rebuild All Screenshots...	Check every scene and retake only those that need it. Choose which connected drives to process, and stop at any time: running it again carries on from there
Tools > Optimise Screenshots	Convert older scenes to the two-file format, using the screenshots they already have, so their drives don't need to be connected
Tools > Clean Up Old Backups...	Remove old automatic catalogue backups



Screenshot Leftovers

Rebuild All Screenshots shows progress for each drive, and lists anything that went wrong. Drag the gap between **Drives** and **Problems** to give the problems more room. The size is kept for next time.



Rebuild All Screenshots, with three problems listed

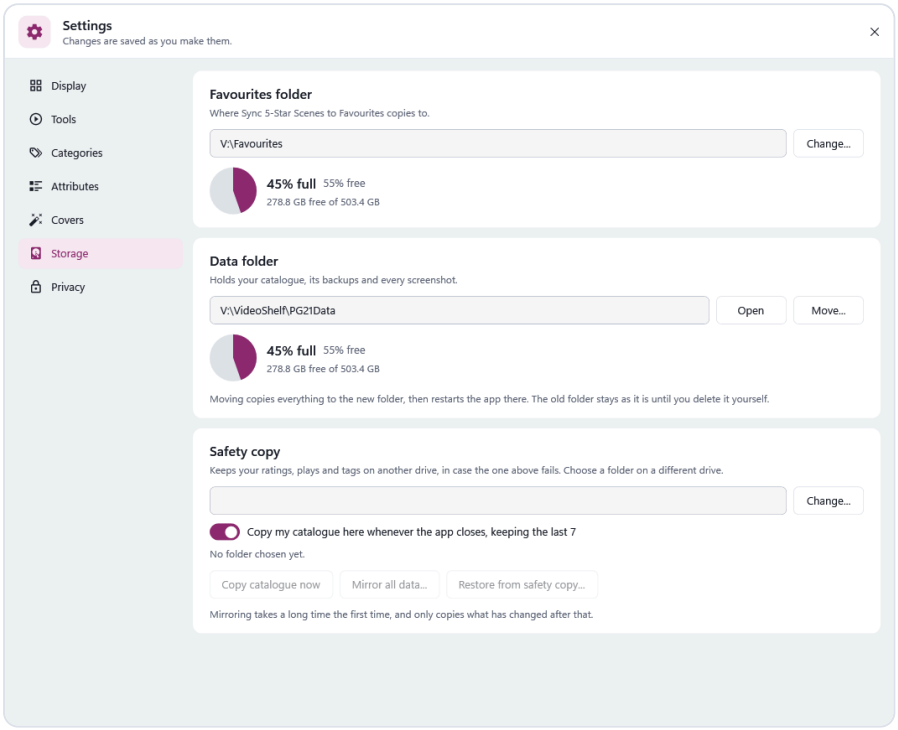
11. Keeping your data safe

Your videos are on your drives, but your ratings, plays and tags exist only in your catalogue. Keeping a copy of it is well worth a minute of setup.

Safety copy

Go to **Settings > Storage** and choose a folder on another drive. You can then:

- Copy the catalogue whenever the app closes, keeping the last seven copies.
- Copy it now.
- Mirror all your data, including screenshots. The first mirror can take a long time, and after that only changes are copied.



Settings: Storage

Clearing every scene tag

To start your scene tags again, use **Clear every scene tag...** at the bottom of **Settings > Storage**. It takes every tag off every scene in your collection. Folders' own tags, categories, attributes, ratings and plays are kept.

Because it can't be undone from the app, you're asked to type a phrase first, such as `walnut-cobalt-44`. It's different every time, so it can't be typed from habit, and it can't be pasted.

Your catalogue is copied to your data folder first, as `index-before-clearing-tags-` followed by the date and time. To bring the tags back, close Video Shelf, rename `index.db.gz` in your data folder to keep it, then copy that file and rename the copy to `index.db.gz`. Anything you changed after clearing is lost by doing so.

Moving your data

To keep your catalogue and screenshots on another drive, use **Move...** under **Data folder** in **Settings > Storage**. The app copies everything, then restarts using the new location. Your old folder isn't touched, so you can delete it once you're happy.

Restoring from your safety copy

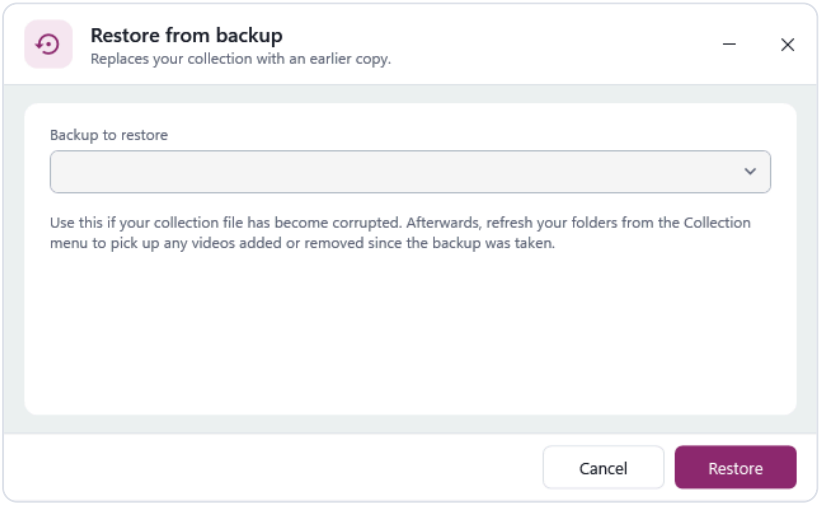
Click **Restore from safety copy...** in **Settings > Storage**, and choose a dated catalogue or your full mirror. A catalogue brings back your ratings, plays, tags and categories. The full mirror brings back everything, including screenshots, copying only what differs.

1. Close any other Video Shelf windows.
2. Choose what to restore, then click **Restore**. The copy is checked before anything changes.
3. Confirm. **Stop** leaves your catalogue as it was.
4. The app restarts. Refresh your folders to pick up anything added or removed since the copy was made.

> **Your current data is kept**
> What you had before is saved in a `before-restore` folder inside your data folder. If the copy had a PIN set, that PIN applies after restoring.

Restoring a backup

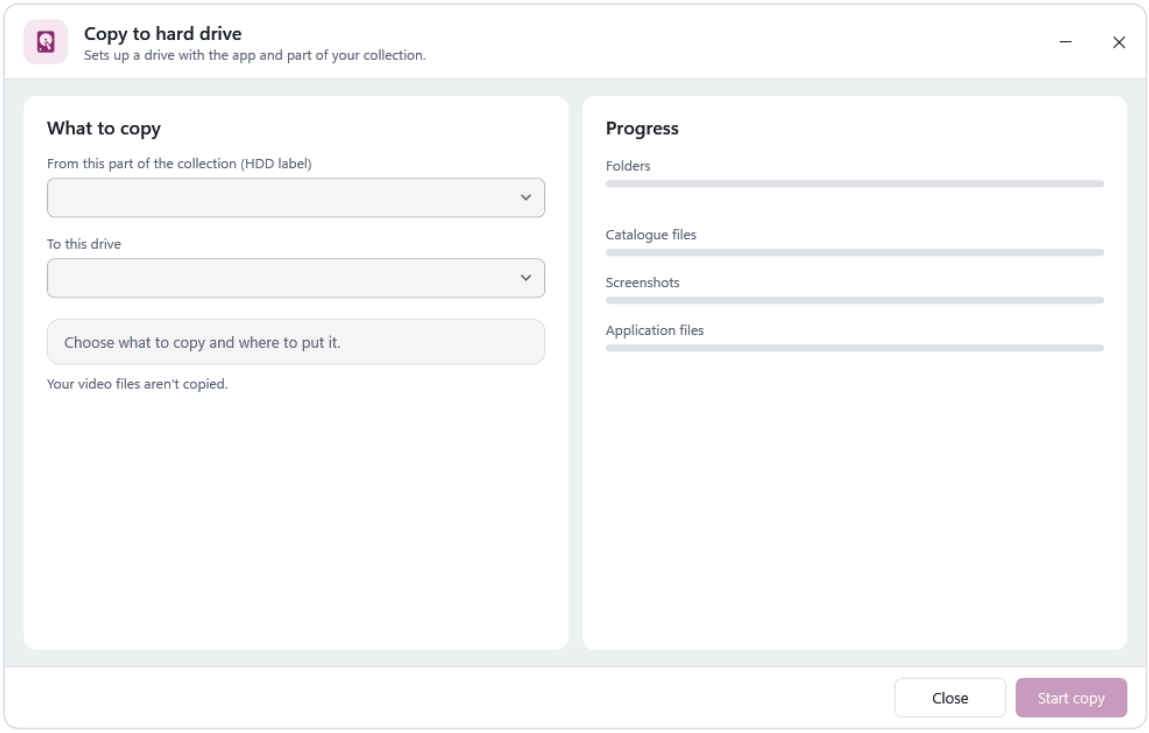
If your catalogue is ever empty or damaged when the app starts, it offers to list your recent backups from the data folder. Choose one, then refresh your folders to pick up anything added since.



Restoring from a backup

Copying to a hard drive

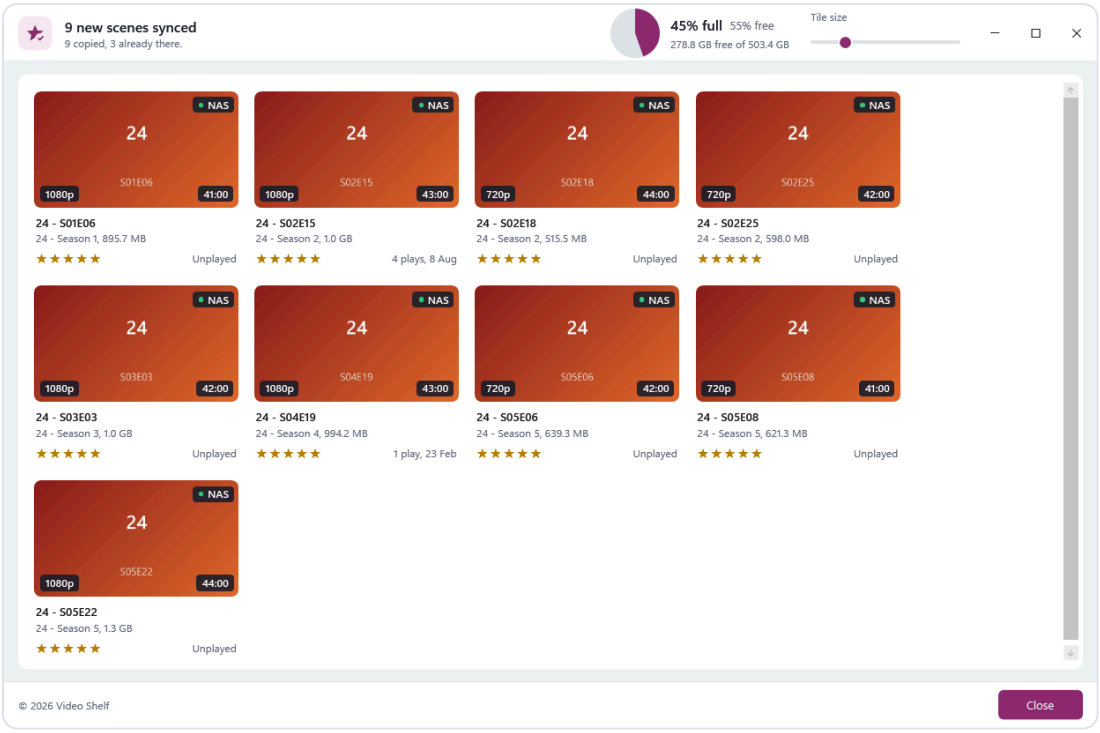
Tools > Initialise HDD Cache... sets up a drive with the app, plus the catalogue and screenshots for part of your collection. You can then browse that part on another PC, as a read-only copy. Your video files aren't copied.



Copy to Hard Drive

Favourites sync

Tools > Sync 5-Star Scenes to Favourites copies your 5-star scenes to one folder, for example on a portable drive. A card below the menus shows progress, speed, time left, and how much room is left on the drive. A results window then shows what was copied.

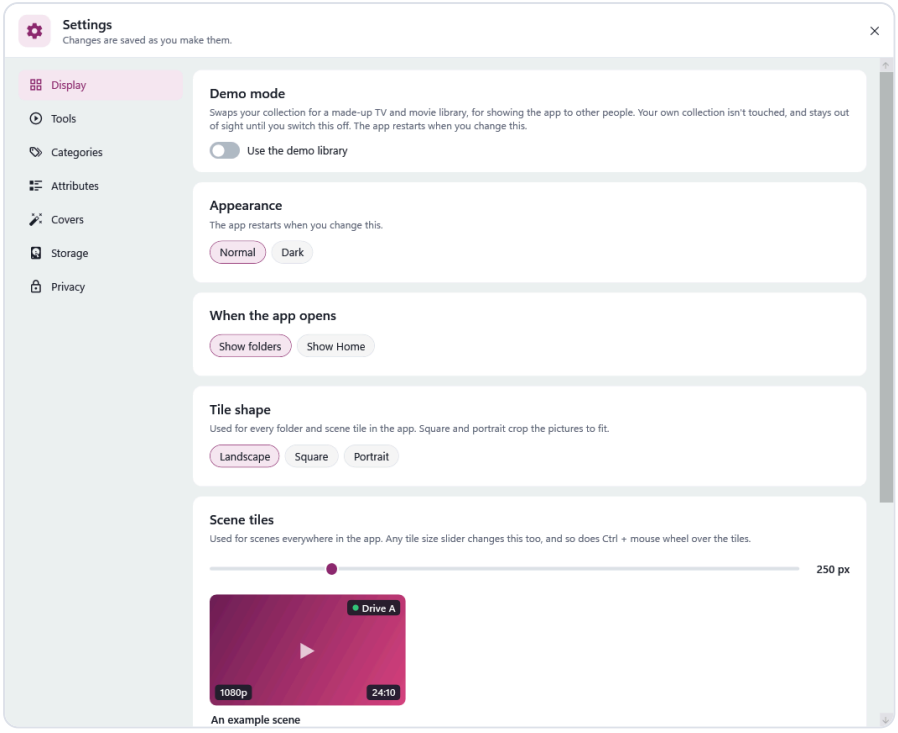


The results of a Favourites sync

12. Settings

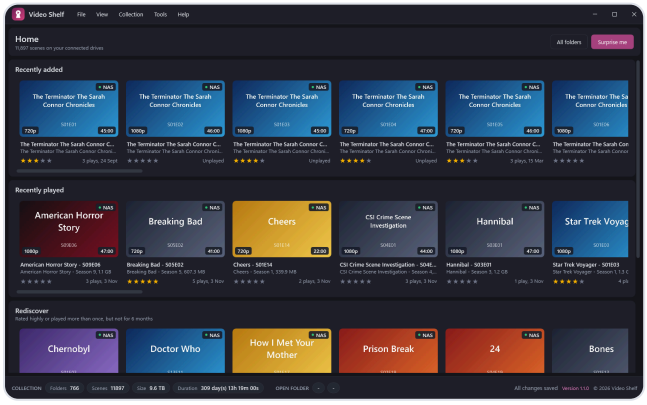
Open **File > Settings...**. Changes are saved as you make them.

Display

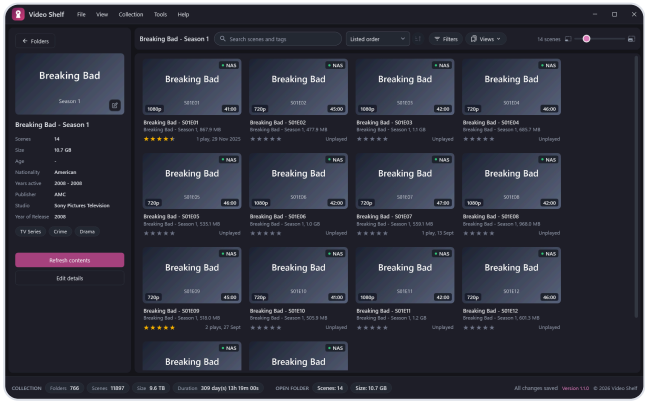


Settings: Display

Setting	What it does
Demo mode	Swaps your collection for a made-up film and TV library, for showing the app to other people. Your own collection stays out of sight, a **Demo** label shows in the title bar, and the app restarts
Appearance	Chooses Normal or Dark. The app restarts
When the app opens	Starts on your folders or on Home
Tile shape	Landscape, Square or Portrait, across the whole app
Scene tiles and **Folder tiles**	Set the size of each, with a preview

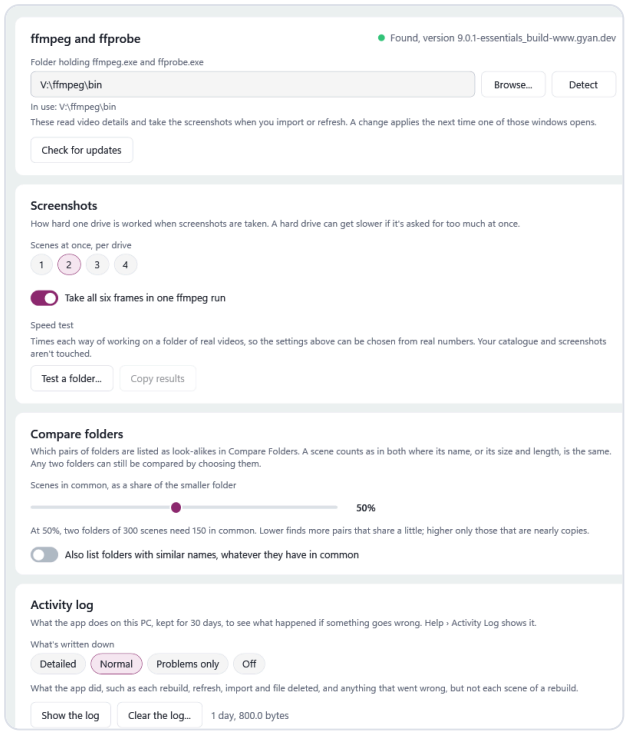


Home in Dark appearance



Scenes in Dark appearance

Tools

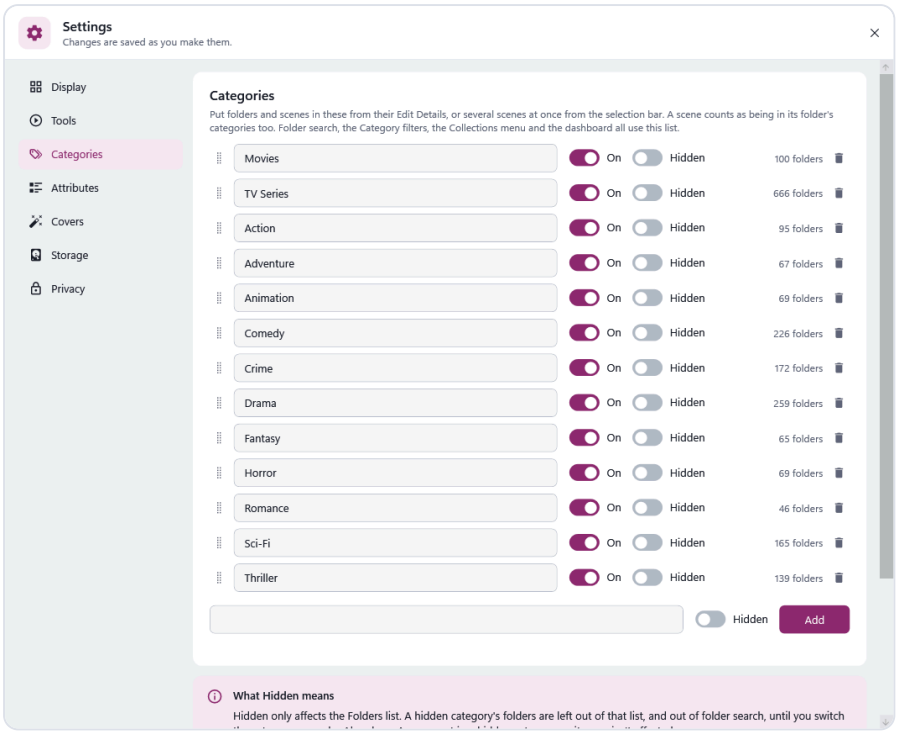


Settings: Tools

- **ffmpeg and ffprobe** read your videos and take screenshots. They aren't included with the app: see chapter 2. **Check for updates** tells you if there's a newer version and can open its download page. It never downloads anything itself. To use a new version, unpack it and click **Browse...** to choose its `bin` folder.
- **Screenshots** sets how many scenes each drive works on at once. **Test a folder...** times the options on your own videos, so you can pick the fastest for your drives.
- **Compare folders** sets how much two folders must have in common to be listed as look-alikes: by default, half the scenes of the smaller folder. A switch also lists folders with similar names, whatever they share, which finds copies saved under other file names.
- **Activity log** sets how much is written down. See chapter 13.

Categories

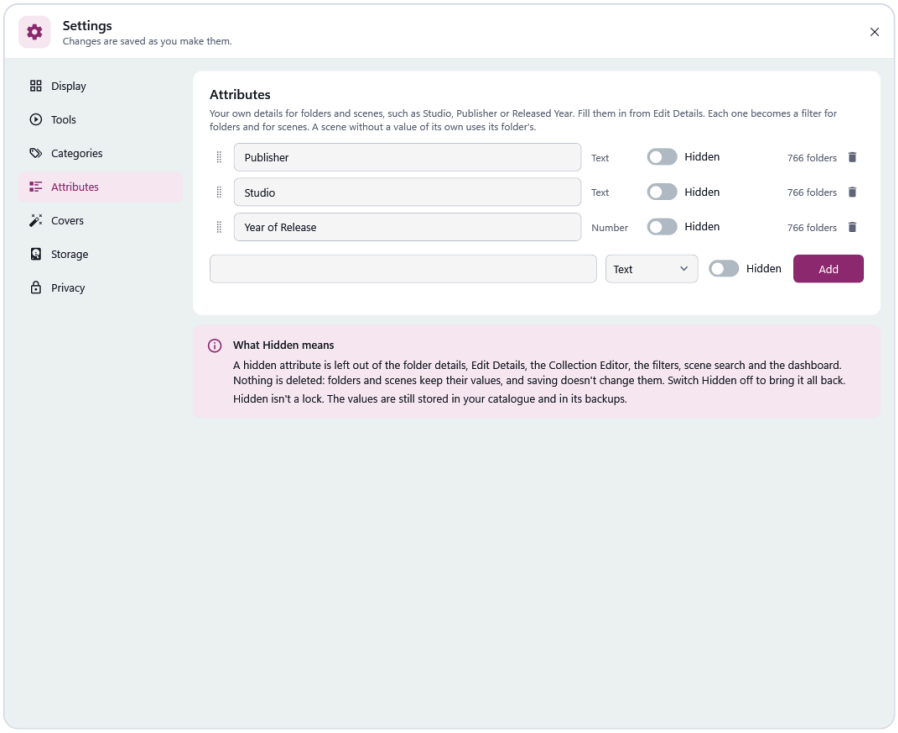
Add, reorder and remove categories, and choose whether each one is on, off or Hidden. If you delete a category that's in use, the app warns you first, then removes it from those folders.



Settings: Categories

Attributes

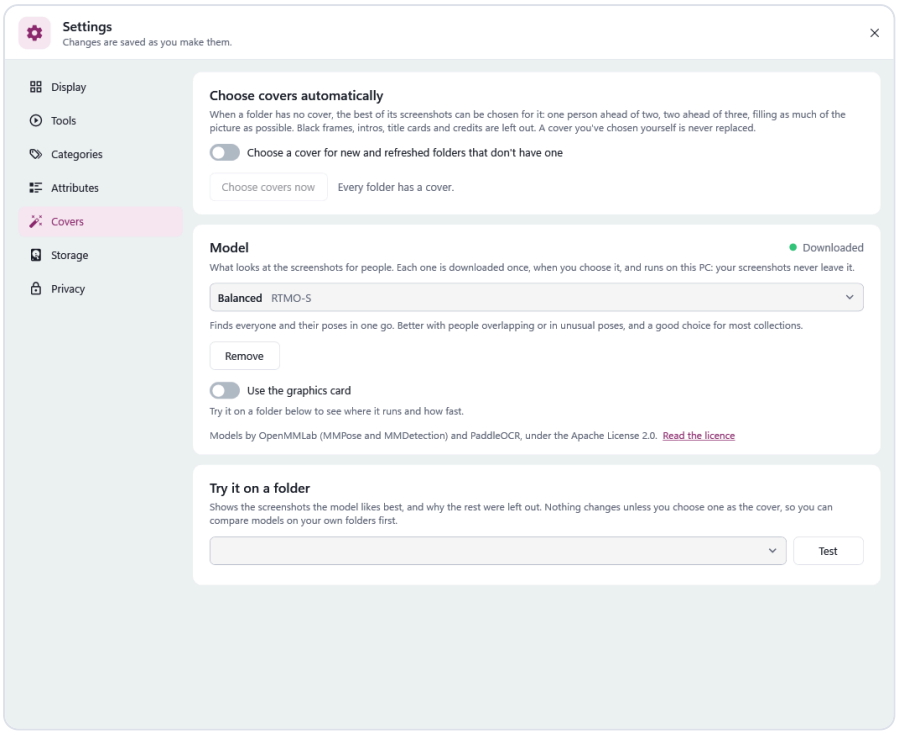
Add details of your own to keep on folders and scenes, such as Studio, Publisher or Year of Release, as text, a number or a date. Drag them into the order you want. **Hidden** takes an attribute out of view without changing the values held, and the count beside each one shows how many folders use it.



Settings: Attributes

Covers

The cover model looks at a folder's screenshots for people, to suggest a cover. It's downloaded once, when you choose it, and runs on your PC: your screenshots never leave it.



Settings: Covers

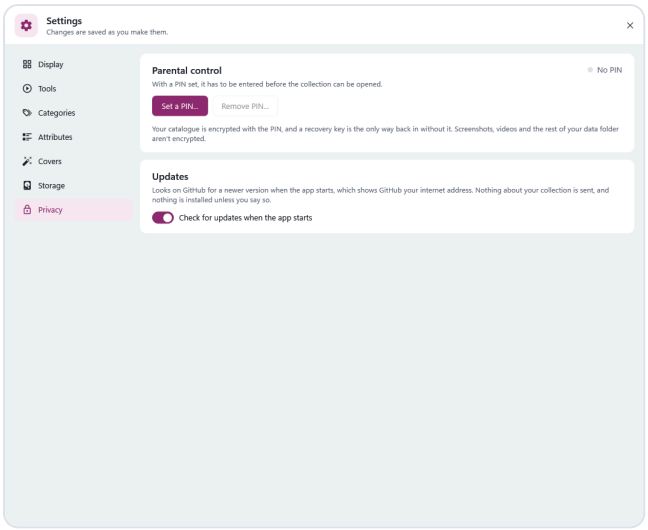
Setting	What it does
Choose a cover for new and refreshed folders	Gives any folder without a cover the best match among its screenshots, after an import or refresh. A cover you've chosen yourself is never replaced
Choose covers now	Does the same for every folder that has no cover
Model	Fast, Balanced or Most accurate. **Download** fetches it, and **Remove** deletes it again
Use the graphics card	Runs the model on the graphics card where it can, taking work off the processor
Try it on a folder	Shows the screenshots the model likes best, and why the rest were left out. Nothing changes unless you choose one

Storage

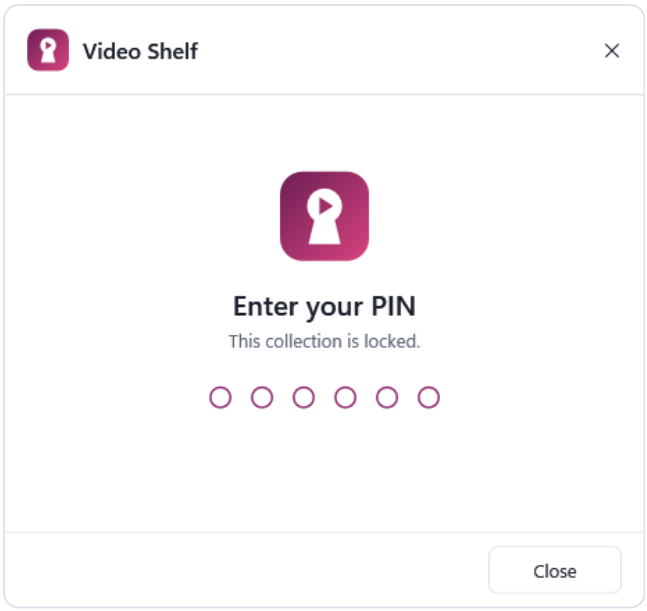
Your Favourites folder, your data folder and your safety copy. See chapter 11.

Privacy

Set a six-digit PIN to lock the app when it starts. Nothing in your collection is shown until the PIN is entered. Switching a category back on also needs the PIN.



Settings: Privacy



The PIN screen at start-up

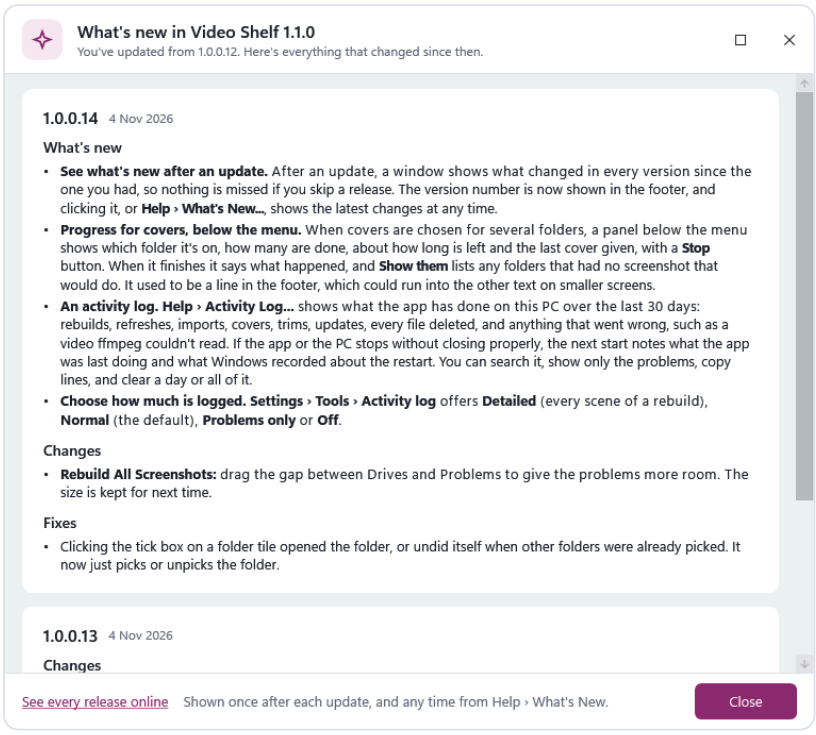
> **Keep your recovery key safe**
> Setting a PIN encrypts your catalogue, and you're shown a recovery key once. If you forget your PIN, click **Forgotten it?** and enter that key. Without either one, the catalogue can't be opened. Screenshots and the rest of your data folder aren't encrypted.

To stop the app looking for updates when it starts, switch off **Check for updates when the app starts**. The check shows GitHub your internet address, and nothing about your collection is sent.

13. Help and reference

What's New

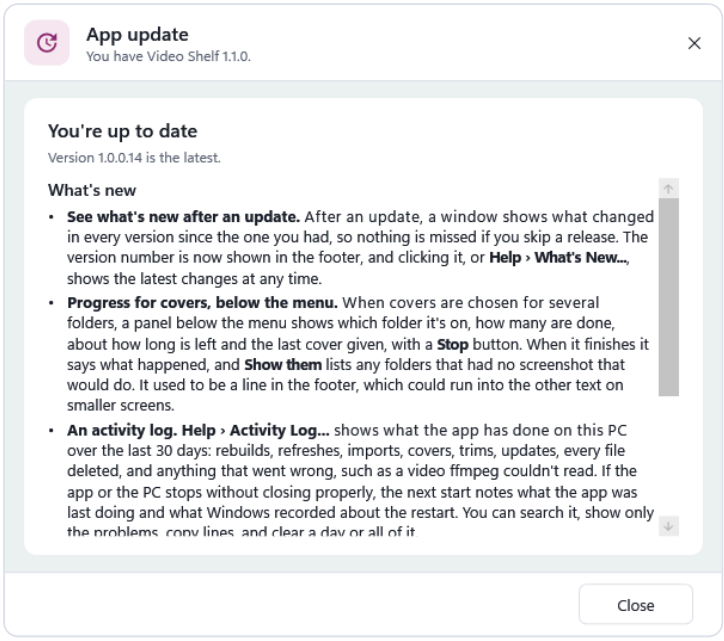
After an update, a window shows what changed in every version since the one you had, so nothing is missed if you skip one. **Help > What's New...**, or the version in the status bar, shows the latest changes at any time. The notes come from the release pages online, so they need an internet connection.



What's New

Updates

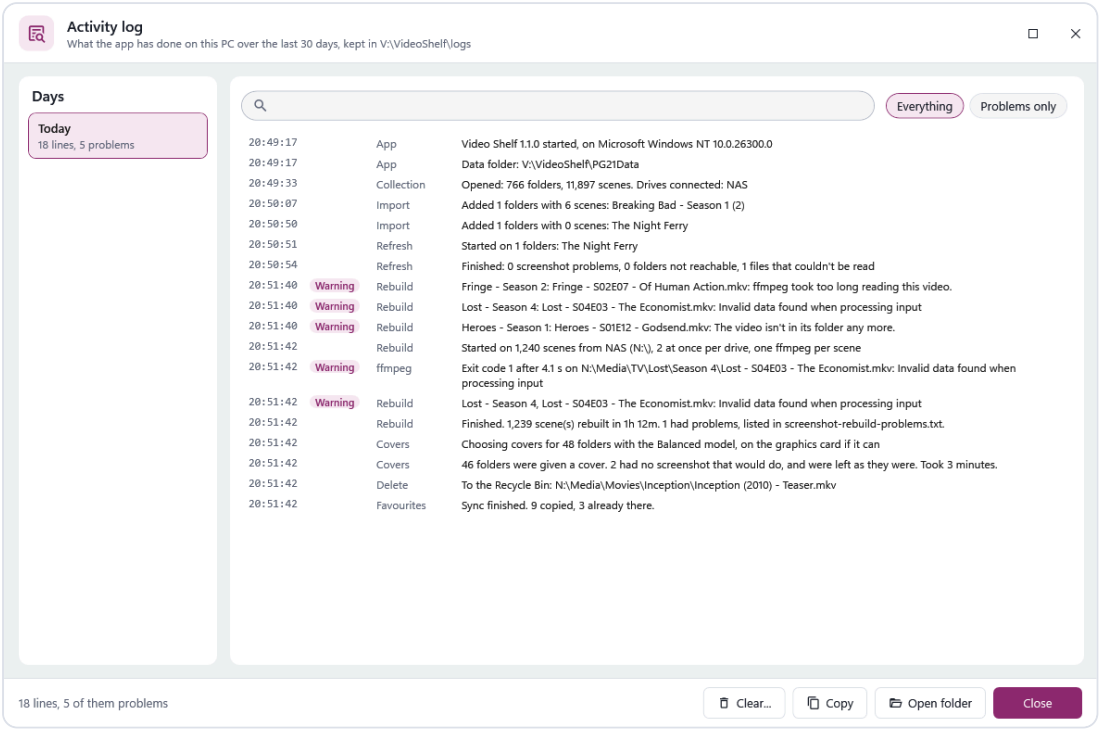
When a new version is published, a button in the status bar offers it. **Help > Check for Updates...** looks straight away. Choose **Download and install** and the app downloads the update, checks it, closes and runs the installer. Your collection isn't touched, and nothing is installed unless you ask.



Checking for updates

The activity log

Help > Activity Log... shows what the app has done on this PC over the last 30 days: rebuilds, refreshes, imports, covers, trims, updates, every file deleted, and anything that went wrong, such as a video ffmpeg couldn't read. Choose a day on the left, search it, or show **Problems only**. **Copy** copies the lines you've picked, **Open folder** shows the log files, and **Clear...** deletes a day or the whole log.



The activity log

If the app or the PC stops without closing properly, the next start notes what the app was last doing, and what Windows recorded about the restart. That helps tell an app problem from a PC one.

Settings > Tools > Activity log sets how much is written down:

Level	What's written
Detailed	Everything, including each scene of a screenshot rebuild. Best for finding out why something went wrong
Normal	What the app did and anything that went wrong, but not each step of a long job. This is where it starts
Problems only	Only what went wrong
Off	Nothing

> **Before you share a log**
> The log names the files the app worked on, with their folders. Bear that in mind if you send it to anyone.

Keyboard and mouse

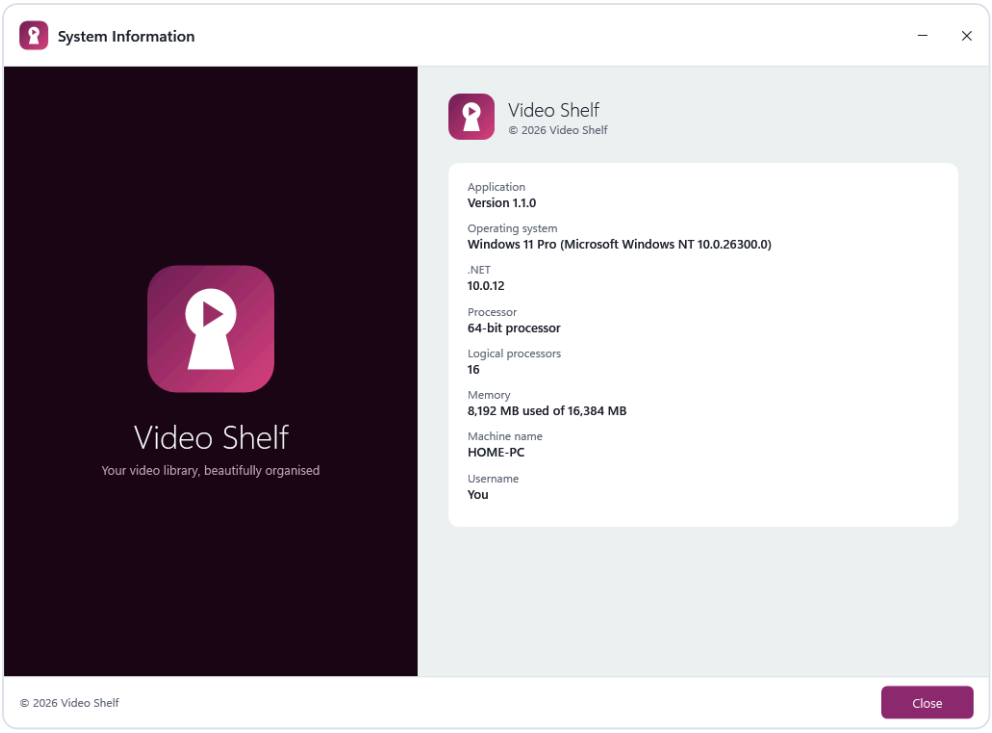
Keys	Action
Ctrl+F	Go to the search box
Ctrl+Shift+F	Open or close the filters
Ctrl + mouse wheel	Change the tile size
Ctrl+A	Pick all the scenes or folders shown
Ctrl + click, **Shift** + click	Add to what's picked, or pick a run
Drag over tiles	Pick an area
Delete	Delete the picked scenes, after asking
Enter	Open the chosen folder, or play the chosen scene
Esc	Close the filters, clear what's picked, or clear a search

Troubleshooting

What you see	What to do
A folder's tiles are dimmed	Its drive isn't connected. Connect it and the folder is available again
"This scene's file can't be found"	Check the drive is connected, then refresh the folder in case the file moved
A file "couldn't be read"	The video may be damaged. Try playing it. It's skipped until a later refresh can read it
Screenshots are missing	Refresh the folder. If the problem stays, see **Collection Health** for the reason, or try a newer ffmpeg
Screenshots take a long time	Try the speed test in **Settings > Tools**
No cover is suggested	Download a model in **Settings > Covers**. If none of a folder's screenshots suits, choose one yourself, or rebuild its screenshots and look again
Too many, or too few, look-alike folders	Change how much they must have in common in **Settings > Tools**
The app or PC stopped part way through a job	Open **Help > Activity Log**. The next start notes what was happening. Set the log to **Detailed** to see each step next time
"Close the other windows first"	Close any other Video Shelf windows, then try again
The drive is full during a sync	The sync copies as many scenes as there's room for, in order

System Information

Help > User Guide opens this guide. **Help > System Information...** shows details of the app and your PC, which are useful if you ever need support. **Help > About...** shows the version and the size of your collection.



System Information